VOLUME 1

# HOW THE PROPHETS SPOKE



THE OFFICE, THE TESTS,
AND THE WORD THE LORD SWEARS

THE PROPHETS SERIES

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# Preface

This volume argues a position. It does not gather what churches say about prophets and leave the reader to choose among them. It says what the author believes the prophets themselves teach about how they spoke, it gives the evidence from their own sentences, and it answers the strongest objections in the objectors' own words, so that a reader who disagrees knows exactly where.

The question is narrow, and the prophets ask it of themselves. By their own statements, how is a word of the LORD known? What can turn an announced oracle aside? And what does the LORD swear, so that nothing turns it? These are not questions imported from outside. Moses raises the first when the people say in their hearts, "How shall we know the word which the LORD hath not spoken?" (Deuteronomy 18:21). Jeremiah raises the second when he stands before the potter's house (Jeremiah 18:7–10). Isaiah, Malachi and Balaam's own oracle raise the third (Isaiah 54:9, 10; Malachi 3:6; Numbers 23:19). The volume follows the prophets as they answer.

The position is this. The prophets give not one test but several, and each answers a different question. A word is the LORD's only if it comes from him and not from the prophet's own heart. It is refused if it leads Israel away from the LORD, whatever sign accompanies it. An announced event must come to pass, unless the LORD has attached a condition to it, as he attached one to Nineveh. And a word the LORD has sworn is a different kind of word from an announcement of judgment or blessing on a nation: it is never turned back. A reader who runs the tests in the wrong order, or applies the test of one kind of word to the other kind, will call true prophets false or false prophets true.

Three things about the method. First, the volume reads the King James Version only, and every Scripture quotation is checked word for word against it. Second, each chapter opens with a claim, reads its passages in order, and closes with a short table and a list of what the volume takes from the passage, so that the reader can see what has been argued and test it. Third, where modern writers are named, they are named for what they say. A writer is quoted only from a text the author has read and that anyone can read for free. Otherwise the position is described in the author's own words and no view is credited to a writer who has not been read.

The volume does not take up the matters its neighbours argue. Revelation 13's false prophet is read in Prophetic Commentary Volume 2, and the prophet like Moses in Acts 3 and 7 in Acts Commentary Volume 1; this volume cites them. It does not argue the sworn covenants of Abraham, David and the New Covenant, which are read in the Covenantal Commentary Series and in Prophetic Identity Volumes 1 and 3, and it uses their conclusions without re-running them. It makes no claim about the Mystery, which Prophecy & Mystery Volume 2 reads. The prophets are read in Israel's setting, where they were spoken.

# Thesis

The prophets give the tests themselves, and the tests are not one rule restated. Where a passage names no test or no condition, the volume says so and builds none.

The thesis in four statements.

| Statement | What it says | Where it is argued |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | A prophet is the LORD's appointed spokesman to Israel, and a word is his only if it comes from him and not from the prophet's own heart. | Chapters 1 and 2 |
| 2 | A word that leads Israel from the LORD is refused whatever sign comes with it; an announced event that does not come to pass was not the LORD's word. | Chapters 3 and 4 |
| 3 | An announced judgment or blessing on a people carries its own condition; the LORD may turn it aside when the people turn. | Chapter 5 |
| 4 | What the LORD swears is another kind of word, and the prophets mark it by its own wording; nothing turns it back. | Chapter 6 |

A reader may test the thesis in one move. Take any prophet's word and ask four questions of it in order: where did it come from, where does it lead, did it come to pass, and did the LORD attach a condition or swear it? If one test could do the work of all four, the thesis fails. If each catches an error the others miss, the thesis stands, and the reader will have seen why the prophets give no single rule.

# 1. The Office

Claim: a prophet in Israel is the LORD's appointed spokesman, not a self-made one. The LORD makes himself known to him, puts words in his mouth, and holds the people to account for hearing. Moses is the measure, and Samuel shows an established prophet whom all Israel knew.

### 1.1 The LORD makes himself known

The first statement of the office is the LORD's own, spoken at the door of the tabernacle to Aaron and Miriam. "Hear now my words: If there be a prophet among you, I the LORD will make myself known unto him in a vision, and will speak unto him in a dream" (Numbers 12:6). The sentence puts the LORD in the active place. The prophet is the one to whom the LORD makes himself known, and the vision and the dream are the LORD's means. Nothing in the verse lets a man become a prophet by deciding to, or by being clever about the future.

The verse also says where the prophet stands: "among you." The office is set in the midst of Israel. Numbers 12 does not describe a prophet of the nations or a prophet to all mankind. It describes the way the LORD speaks to the one who is to speak to Israel, and it is spoken in the camp of Israel in the wilderness.

### 1.2 Moses the measure

The next verses set a standard above the ordinary prophet. “My servant Moses is not so, who is faithful in all mine house. With him will I speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, and not in dark speeches; and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold” (Numbers 12:7, 8). Moses is distinguished from the prophet of the dream and the vision by the directness of the speaking: mouth to mouth, plainly, and not in dark speeches. The LORD then asks Aaron and Miriam why they were not afraid to speak against him.

The point for this volume is not a ranking of prophets for its own sake. It is that the LORD himself sets a measure. Whatever else a prophet is, he is compared with the man who received the Law, and a word that contradicts what Moses received does not stand. The tests of Deuteronomy 13 and 18 depend on this. Moses is the one by whom Israel knows the LORD’s commandments, and those commandments are the fixed point against which every later oracle is held.

### 1.3 Raised up, and the words put in his mouth

Moses himself describes the office to Israel in the plainest terms. “The LORD thy God will raise up unto thee a Prophet from the midst of thee, of thy brethren, like unto me; unto him ye shall hearken” (Deuteronomy 18:15). Three phrases carry the office. He is raised up by the LORD. He comes from the midst of Israel, of their brethren. And Israel is commanded to hearken to him.

Moses then says why the office exists. It answers what the people asked at Horeb: “Let me not hear again the voice of the LORD my God, neither let me see this great fire any more, that I die not” (Deuteronomy 18:16). The LORD’s reply to the request is that they had “well spoken” (Deuteronomy 18:17). The prophet therefore stands between a holy God and a people who cannot bear his voice, and the LORD approves the arrangement the people asked for. He promises, “I will raise them up a Prophet from among their brethren, like unto thee, and will put my words in his mouth; and he shall speak unto them all that I shall command him” (Deuteronomy 18:18).

Two limits follow in the same breath. The prophet speaks “all that I shall command him,” which is a limit on what he may add. And the hearer is held to account: “whosoever will not hearken unto my words which he shall speak in my name, I will require it of him” (Deuteronomy 18:19). The office carries authority because the words are the LORD’s, and the same fact limits it. A prophet whose words are his own has no claim on the hearer. Chapter 4 takes up the verses that follow, which deal with the prophet who presumes to speak what the LORD did not command.

The Acts Commentary Series reads Deuteronomy 18:15–19 as the promise of the prophet whom Peter and Stephen name in Acts 3 and 7 (Acts Commentary Volume 1). That reading is not re-argued here. This volume asks what the passage says about the office as the prophets practised it, and for that purpose the passage is plain: the prophet is raised up by the LORD, comes from among Israel’s brethren, carries the LORD’s words and no others, and is known by the tests the passage goes on to give.

### 1.4 Samuel, whom all Israel knew

First Samuel gives a case. “And Samuel grew, and the LORD was with him, and did let none of his words fall to the ground. And all Israel from Dan even to Beersheba knew that Samuel was established to be a prophet of the LORD” (1 Samuel 3:19, 20). The

two sentences tie two things together. The LORD let none of Samuel's words fall to the ground, and all Israel knew that he was established. Recognition by the nation followed the word coming to pass, and the text gives no other ground for it.

The next verse names the source: "the LORD appeared again in Shiloh: for the LORD revealed himself to Samuel in Shiloh by the word of the LORD" (1 Samuel 3:21). Samuel does not originate anything. The LORD reveals himself by the word of the LORD, and the word is what Samuel carries. The chapter answers Numbers 12:6 in a living man: the LORD made himself known, and the prophet spoke what he was given.

**1.5 What Amos 3:7 says, and what it does not**

Amos states the pattern as a principle: "Surely the Lord GOD will do nothing, but he revealeth his secret unto his servants the prophets" (Amos 3:7). The volume reads the verse as the LORD's way with his prophets concerning what he is about to do in Israel's history. When he is about to act in judgment or deliverance, he tells the prophets first. That is why the prophets could warn, and why Amos can ask, in the verses around it, whether a trumpet can be blown in a city and the people not be afraid.

The volume does not read the verse as saying that everything God purposes was told to the prophets. The sentence is about what the LORD "will do" in the course he has announced to his servants, and it says that he reveals it to them before it happens. A secret kept hid in God from the ages is a different matter, and Prophecy & Mystery Volume 2 argues that it was not foretold by the prophets. Amos 3:7 does not contradict that. It describes the announced events of Israel's history and the LORD's habit of announcing them.

The office in five passages.

| Passage | What it says of the prophet | Verse |
|---|---|---|
| Numbers 12:6–8 | The LORD makes himself known in vision and dream; Moses is the measure, mouth to mouth | 12:6–8 |
| Deuteronomy 18:15–19 | Raised up by the LORD, from the midst of Israel; words put in his mouth; the hearer held to account | 18:15, 18, 19 |
| 1 Samuel 3:19–21 | None of his words fell to the ground; all Israel knew he was established; the LORD revealed himself by the word | 3:19–21 |
| Amos 3:7 | The LORD reveals to the prophets what he will do, before he does it | 3:7 |
| What is unsaid | Whether every prophecy was understood by the one who spoke it; what the Mystery was; how a man in the moment tells a true prophet | Chapters 2, 4 and 7 |

### 1.6 The mouth: Exodus 4

The office has a plain picture at its beginning, before any prophet is named. Moses pleads that he is “slow of speech, and of a slow tongue” (Exodus 4:10). The LORD answers with a question that takes the matter out of Moses’ hands: “Who hath made man’s mouth?” (Exodus 4:11). Then comes the promise: “Now therefore go, and I will be with thy mouth, and teach thee what thou shalt say” (Exodus 4:12). The speaker is sent, the words are taught, and the mouth is the LORD’s to give.

When Moses asks again to be excused, the LORD provides Aaron, and the arrangement he describes is the pattern of the whole office in small. “And thou shalt speak unto him, and put words in his mouth: and I will be with thy mouth, and with his mouth, and will teach you what ye shall do” (Exodus 4:15). The word passes from the LORD to Moses, from Moses to Aaron, and from Aaron to the people. “And he shall be thy spokesman unto the people: and he shall be, even he shall be to thee instead of a mouth, and thou shalt be to him instead of God” (Exodus 4:16).

Three things follow, and the volume will hold them through every later chapter. First, the one who speaks is not the author. Aaron is “instead of a mouth,” and a mouth has nothing of its own to say. Second, the words are given beforehand, and the teaching is the LORD’s: “teach thee what thou shalt say.” A prophet does not compose a message and then ask the LORD to bless it. Third, the hearers are not asked to judge Aaron’s eloquence. Moses had said he was not eloquent, and the LORD did not answer that he would become so. The authority of the word did not rest on the quality of the mouth.

This is the argument against the claim, still made, that a true prophet is known by the force of his speech or the warmth of his manner. The LORD chose a man who said he could not speak well, and he made a second man to be his mouth. The tests the prophets later give do not examine the speaker’s gifts. They ask where the word came from, where it leads, and whether it stands. Exodus 4 shows why. The mouth was never what made the word true.

### 1.7 What the volume takes from the passages

- A prophet is the LORD’s spokesman, made known and sent by him; no man is a prophet by his own decision.
- Moses is the measure, and the commandments received through him are the fixed point against which later oracles are held.
- The words are the LORD’s and are put in the prophet’s mouth; the hearer is held to account for hearing them.
- Samuel shows the office at work: none of his words fell to the ground, and all Israel knew it.
- Amos 3:7 speaks of announced events, not of every purpose of God.
- The words are put in the prophet’s mouth, as Exodus 4:12, 15 shows: the one who speaks is the mouth and not the author, and the speaker’s gifts are not the test.

## 2. The Source

Claim: the first question to ask of a prophet’s word is where it came from. Jeremiah 23 and Ezekiel 13 answer it in the LORD’s own words: a word is his if the prophet

stood in his counsel and was sent, and it is not his if it is the vision of the prophet's own heart. Conduct is evidence of the source, but it is not the test.

### 2.1 The charge: not sent, not spoken to

Jeremiah 23 opens with the prophet's own distress. "Mine heart within me is broken because of the prophets; all my bones shake" (Jeremiah 23:9). The LORD then names two things wrong with the prophets of Samaria and of Jerusalem. Of Samaria: "they prophesied in Baal, and caused my people Israel to err" (Jeremiah 23:13). Of Jerusalem: "they commit adultery, and walk in lies: they strengthen also the hands of evildoers, that none doth return from his wickedness" (Jeremiah 23:14). The first charge is what they prophesied by, the second is how they lived and what their living did to the people.

Wessels, in a study of this passage, draws the conclusion that the rival prophets of Jeremiah 23:9–15 are known to be false by their conduct and because the LORD did not send them (Wessels, in the Journal for Semitics). The volume agrees as far as the text goes, and notes where the text carries the weight. Verse 14 puts the conduct plainly, and verse 21 gives the reason that the conduct is evidence of: "I have not sent these prophets, yet they ran: I have not spoken to them, yet they prophesied" (Jeremiah 23:21). Conduct points toward the source. The source itself is stated in verse 21.

### 2.2 Whose heart the vision comes from

The decisive sentence is in verse 16. "Thus saith the LORD of hosts, Hearken not unto the words of the prophets that prophesy unto you: they make you vain: they speak a vision of their own heart, and not out of the mouth of the LORD" (Jeremiah 23:16). The test is a question of origin. A vision is either out of the mouth of the LORD or out of the heart of the man. The people are told not to hearken to the second kind, and the instruction is given on that ground and on no other.

The next verse shows what such a vision sounds like and who likes it. "They say still unto them that despise me, The LORD hath said, Ye shall have peace; and they say unto every one that walketh after the imagination of his own heart, No evil shall come upon you" (Jeremiah 23:17). The false word says what the hearer already wishes. It uses the LORD's name, "The LORD hath said," and it offers peace to the very people who despise him. This is the pattern the volume will meet again at Jeremiah 28 and in 1 Kings 22, and Diamond's observation about Ahab, taken up in chapter 8, belongs here.

### 2.3 Who has stood in the counsel of the LORD

The LORD gives the positive mark in a question. "For who hath stood in the counsel of the LORD, and hath perceived and heard his word? who hath marked his word, and heard it?" (Jeremiah 23:18). Then, of the false prophets: "But if they had stood in my counsel, and had caused my people to hear my words, then they should have turned them from their evil way, and from the evil of their doings" (Jeremiah 23:22). The true prophet has been in the LORD's counsel, and the effect of his word is to turn the people from evil. The false prophet has not been there, and the effect of his word is to strengthen the hands of evildoers (Jeremiah 23:14).

The LORD adds two warnings against passing off a dream as his word. "The prophet that hath a dream, let him tell a dream; and he that hath my word, let him speak my

word faithfully. What is the chaff to the wheat?" (Jeremiah 23:28). A dream may be told as a dream. What is forbidden is giving it the standing of the LORD's word. Then the force of the true word: "Is not my word like as a fire? saith the LORD; and like a hammer that breaketh the rock in pieces?" (Jeremiah 23:29). The question of source is therefore also a question of effect, but the text puts the source first.

Prophetic Commentary Volume 2 reads Jeremiah 23:25 and 27 as part of its argument about the false prophet of Revelation 13. This volume does not take up that identification. It reads the same sentences for what they say of every prophet in Jeremiah's day: those who say "I have dreamed, I have dreamed" in the LORD's name are, in his words, "prophets of the deceit of their own heart" (Jeremiah 23:25, 26).

**2.4 Ezekiel 13: the same test, a generation on**

Ezekiel is commanded to prophesy against "the prophets of Israel that prophesy, and say thou unto them that prophesy out of their own hearts, Hear ye the word of the LORD" (Ezekiel 13:2). The woe is on "the foolish prophets, that follow their own spirit, and have seen nothing" (Ezekiel 13:3). The test is the same as Jeremiah's, and the wording is almost the same: their prophecy is from their own hearts, and the LORD has not sent them. "They have seen vanity and lying divination, saying, The LORD saith: and the LORD hath not sent them" (Ezekiel 13:6). Again: "Have ye not seen a vain vision, and have ye not spoken a lying divination, whereas ye say, The LORD saith it; albeit I have not spoken?" (Ezekiel 13:7).

Ezekiel adds the judgment on such prophets: "they shall not be in the assembly of my people, neither shall they be written in the writing of the house of Israel, neither shall they enter into the land of Israel" (Ezekiel 13:9). The prophets are cut off from the register of Israel and from the land. Study 68 reads Ezekiel 13:9 as one of the registers of names; this volume reads it as the LORD's sentence on prophets who spoke from their own hearts. The two uses do not conflict.

Between the two prophets, two generations apart, the same question is asked of the same kind of word. That fact matters for the volume's thesis. The test of source is not peculiar to one prophet's circumstances. It is the LORD's own standard, applied by Jeremiah in Jerusalem before the exile and by Ezekiel among the exiles.

**2.5 Why conduct is evidence and not the test**

Conduct is real evidence. Jeremiah 23:14 names adultery and lies, and Jeremiah 23:10 and 11 name the profaneness of prophet and priest. But the volume holds that conduct is not the test, for two reasons drawn from the text. First, the LORD gives the test as origin: "not out of the mouth of the LORD" (Jeremiah 23:16). A man might live well and still speak from his own heart, and the passage does not say that good conduct validates a vision. Second, the LORD's own complaint is stated as a fact about the sending: "I have not sent these prophets" (Jeremiah 23:21). Conduct tells the hearer something about the likelihood. The sending is the question.

The test of source in Jeremiah 23 and Ezekiel 13.

| Mark | False prophet | True prophet |
|---|---|---|
| Sent? | "I have not sent these prophets, yet they ran" (Jeremiah 23:21) | Sent by the LORD (Jeremiah 26:12) |
| Where from? | "a vision of their own heart" (Jeremiah 23:16); "out of their own hearts" (Ezekiel 13:2) | "stood in the counsel of the LORD" (Jeremiah 23:18) |
| Effect on hearers | Peace to those who despise him; strengthens evildoers (Jeremiah 23:14, 17) | Turns them from their evil way (Jeremiah 23:22) |
| The LORD's verdict | "I am against the prophets" (Jeremiah 23:30); not in the register of Israel (Ezekiel 13:9) | "he that hath my word, let him speak my word faithfully" (Jeremiah 23:28) |

**2.6 Micah: full of power by the spirit of the LORD**

The charge of Jeremiah 23 is not Jeremiah's alone. A century earlier Micah describes the same trade and gives its mark. The LORD speaks "concerning the prophets that make my people err, that bite with their teeth, and cry, Peace; and he that putteth not into their mouths, they even prepare war against him" (Micah 3:5). The prophets cry "Peace" to the man who feeds them and prepare war against the man who does not. Their word follows the table. That is as plain a description of a word that comes from the prophet's own interest as the Scripture gives.

The judgment is a silence. "Therefore night shall be unto you, that ye shall not have a vision; and it shall be dark unto you, that ye shall not divine" (Micah 3:6). The seers "shall all cover their lips; for there is no answer of God" (Micah 3:7). The last clause is the point. A prophet is a man to whom God answers, and when the answer stops, the trade has nothing left to sell. The false prophet's craft was to go on speaking when the LORD had stopped.

Micah then puts himself beside them, and what he says of himself is the positive side of the test of source. "But truly I am full of power by the spirit of the LORD, and of judgment, and of might, to declare unto Jacob his transgression, and to Israel his sin" (Micah 3:8). He does not offer a reputation, a school or a sign. He says the word he carries comes by the spirit of the LORD, and he names its content: the transgression of Jacob and the sin of Israel. The true prophet claims a source and takes the consequences of the claim.

The volume argues from this that the source of a word shows itself in what the word does to its hearers. A word that exposes "his transgression" and "his sin" is a word that costs the one who carries it, and Micah's peers prepared war against the man who would not feed them. The word that cries "Peace" is not wrong because it is gentle. It is wrong when the people's sin is unspoken and the speaker is paid for the silence. Lamentations 2:14 gives the verdict in a single sentence: "Thy prophets have seen vain and foolish things for thee: and they have not discovered thine iniquity, to turn away thy captivity." A prophecy that does not uncover iniquity cannot turn captivity, and the captivity came.

### 2.7 What the volume takes from the passages

- The first question of any prophetic word is where it came from: out of the mouth of the LORD, or out of the prophet's own heart.
- A word the prophet has stood in the LORD's counsel to receive turns the hearers from evil; a word from his own heart comforts them in it.
- Conduct is evidence of the source and is not the test; the LORD states the test as sending and speaking.
- A dream may be told as a dream; it may not be given the standing of the LORD's word.
- Jeremiah and Ezekiel, a generation apart, apply the same test in the same terms.
- Micah 3:5–8 and Lamentations 2:14 give the mark of the paid word: it cries "Peace" and leaves the iniquity unspoken; the true prophet is full of power by the spirit of the LORD to declare the transgression.

# 3. The Test of Loyalty

Claim: Moses gives Israel a test that no sign can pass. A prophet whose sign comes true is still refused if he says, "Let us go after other gods" (Deuteronomy 13:2). Jeremiah applies the same test to Hananiah. The test of loyalty is about where the word leads, and it stands apart from the test of whether the word comes to pass.

### 3.1 A sign that comes to pass

Deuteronomy 13 begins with a case that looks, at first, as though it should be easy. "If there arise among you a prophet, or a dreamer of dreams, and giveth thee a sign or a wonder, and the sign or the wonder come to pass, whereof he spake unto thee, saying, Let us go after other gods, which thou hast not known, and let us serve them" (Deuteronomy 13:1, 2). The prophet gives a sign. He speaks of it beforehand, and it comes to pass. By any test that stopped there he would be vindicated.

The next verse refuses him. "Thou shalt not hearken unto the words of that prophet, or that dreamer of dreams: for the LORD your God proveth you, to know whether ye love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul" (Deuteronomy 13:3). The sign came to pass, and the prophet is to be refused. Moses gives the reason in the same verse. The sign is not evidence of the LORD's sending. It is the LORD's proving of the people. What is being tested is not the prophet's power to foretell but Israel's love for the LORD.

That fact fixes the volume's second position. A fulfilled sign cannot validate a word that leads from the LORD. Chapter 4 will argue that an unfulfilled word is enough to show that the LORD did not speak it (Deuteronomy 18:22). The two chapters together are lopsided on purpose: failure can condemn, but success alone cannot approve. The test of loyalty is what remains when the sign has come true.

### 3.2 The fixed point

The loyalty test needs something to measure by, and Moses names it in the next verse. "Ye shall walk after the LORD your God, and fear him, and keep his commandments, and obey his voice, and ye shall serve him, and cleave unto him" (Deuteronomy 13:4). The measure is the LORD's commandments, the ones already given through Moses. This is the same Moses of Numbers 12:7, 8, to whom the LORD spoke mouth to mouth. A prophet who speaks against the commandments is refused

whether or not his sign comes to pass, because the commandments came by plainer speech than any later dream.

It follows that the prophets did not add commandments to the Law as though they were its new lawgivers. They called Israel back to the commandments, and they announced what the LORD would do in judgment and mercy. This is the pattern the volume has seen in Jeremiah 23:22: the true word "turned them from their evil way." The prophets of the other kind turned them away from the LORD, and the test of loyalty detects that.

**3.3 The sentence**

The penalty is severe, and it is severe because of what the prophet has done. "And that prophet, or that dreamer of dreams, shall be put to death; because he hath spoken to turn you away from the LORD your God, which brought you out of the land of Egypt, and redeemed you out of the house of bondage, to thrust thee out of the way which the LORD thy God commanded thee to walk in" (Deuteronomy 13:5). The ground of the sentence is stated: he has spoken to turn Israel away from the LORD who redeemed them. The sentence is under the Law of Moses, to Israel in the land. The volume reports it as the Law's sentence on that offence in that setting and carries it no further.

**3.4 Hananiah**

Jeremiah 28 shows the test at work. Hananiah speaks in the house of the LORD before the priests and the people. "Thus speaketh the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel, saying, I have broken the yoke of the king of Babylon" (Jeremiah 28:2). He names a term: "Within two full years will I bring again into this place all the vessels of the LORD's house" (Jeremiah 28:3). He uses the LORD's name, he speaks in the LORD's house, and he speaks of the LORD's own vessels. Nothing in his manner is crude. The people had every reason to believe him, because he said what they wished.

Jeremiah's answer, after the word of the LORD comes to him, is the test of loyalty in a sentence. "Hear now, Hananiah; The LORD hath not sent thee; but thou makest this people to trust in a lie" (Jeremiah 28:15). Then the ground: "because thou hast taught rebellion against the LORD" (Jeremiah 28:16). The Hebrew noun behind "rebellion" here is the one behind "turn you away" in Deuteronomy 13:5, and the sentence on Hananiah is the sentence of that chapter. The volume does not suppose that Jeremiah had the Deuteronomy passage open before him. It observes that he uses its charge and that Hananiah's end follows its pattern: he died "the same year in the seventh month" (Jeremiah 28:17).

The words are the same as Deuteronomy 13 in what they judge. The charge is not that Hananiah mistook a date. The charge is that he made the people trust in a lie and taught rebellion against the LORD. The test applied is the test of source, "The LORD hath not sent thee," joined to the test of loyalty, "rebellion against the LORD." The test of fulfilment does not appear in the verdict at all. Hananiah's death in the seventh month fell within the two months after the prophecy, and it is the LORD's act, as the verdict says, not a measure of whether Hananiah's two years had run.

**3.5 Baal, and the forgetting of the name**

The Jeremiah 23 charges already included this test. Samaria's prophets "prophesied in Baal" (Jeremiah 23:13). The dreamers of Jerusalem thought "to cause my people to

forget my name by their dreams which they tell every man to his neighbour, as their fathers have forgotten my name for Baal" (Jeremiah 23:27). Forgetting the LORD's name for another is the charge of Deuteronomy 13, in the words of Jeremiah. The test of loyalty therefore stands under the test of source in Jeremiah's own chapter. The prophet whose vision comes from his own heart ends by leading the people from the LORD, and the two tests catch the same offender from two sides.

The test of loyalty in Deuteronomy 13 and Jeremiah 28.

| Question | Deuteronomy 13:1–5 | Jeremiah 28:15–17 |
|---|---|---|
| Is there a sign? | Yes: the sign or the wonder comes to pass (13:2) | A prophecy and a symbol: the yoke broken (28:2, 10) |
| Where does the word lead? | "Let us go after other gods" (13:2) | The people "trust in a lie" (28:15) |
| What is the people's test? | The LORD proves whether they love him (13:3) | The word of the LORD to Jeremiah after the yoke is broken (28:12) |
| What is the charge? | "hath spoken to turn you away from the LORD" (13:5) | "hast taught rebellion against the LORD" (28:16) |
| What follows? | The prophet is put to death (13:5) | Hananiah dies the same year (28:17) |

### 3.6 To the law and to the testimony

Isaiah gives the test of loyalty its shortest form in a day when many voices claimed to speak for the dead and the unseen. "And when they shall say unto you, Seek unto them that have familiar spirits, and unto wizards that peep, and that mutter: should not a people seek unto their God? for the living to the dead?" (Isaiah 8:19). Then the rule: "To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them" (Isaiah 8:20).

The volume reads Isaiah 8:20 as the same rule as Deuteronomy 13, said by a prophet to his own generation. The measure is the law and the testimony, a fixed word already given. The verdict on a voice that fails it is not that it is mistaken or weak. It is that "there is no light in them." The ground is the word given through Moses, and a later voice is held to it. The prophets do not ask Israel to believe them because they say so; they send Israel back to what the LORD has already said and ask whether the new word agrees.

This is why the loyalty test works when a sign cannot. A sign can be borrowed or imitated, and Deuteronomy 13 allows that a sign may even come to pass. A fixed word cannot be imitated by a stranger without contradicting itself. The test is therefore the surest the prophets give for a day when feeling runs high and the crowd wants a word. It was the test Israel could apply without waiting for an outcome.

### 3.7 The prophets in Babylon

Jeremiah 29 shows the test applied to a second audience. The letter is written to the exiles, who had their own prophets and diviners, and the instruction is direct. "Let not

your prophets and your diviners, that be in the midst of you, deceive you, neither hearken to your dreams which ye cause to be dreamed. For they prophesy falsely unto you in my name: I have not sent them, saith the LORD" (Jeremiah 29:8, 9). Two tests stand together in one verse. The prophets speak "in my name," which is the claim of sending, and the LORD answers "I have not sent them," which is the test of source.

Then the LORD names two men, Ahab the son of Kolaiah and Zedekiah the son of Maaseiah, "which prophesy a lie unto you in my name" (Jeremiah 29:21). The charge adds a second element to the lie. "They have committed villany in Israel, and have committed adultery with their neighbours' wives, and have spoken lying words in my name, which I have not commanded them; even I know, and am a witness, saith the LORD" (Jeremiah 29:23). Here the text itself joins conduct to the false word. The volume holds the order it has argued since chapter 2: conduct is evidence, the LORD is the witness, and the charge that decides is that the words were "not commanded."

The captives themselves took up a curse from the case: "The LORD make thee like Zedekiah and like Ahab, whom the king of Babylon roasted in the fire" (Jeremiah 29:22). A false word given in the LORD's name was remembered by a nation and made into a proverb. It shows how seriously Israel took the test of loyalty and source, and how long the memory of a failed prophet could last.

### 3.8 What the volume takes from the passages

- A sign that comes to pass does not validate a word that leads Israel from the LORD.
- The measure is the LORD's commandments, given through Moses and fixed before any later prophet spoke.
- Failure can condemn a prophet and success alone cannot approve him; the test of loyalty remains when the sign has come true.
- Jeremiah answers Hananiah by the tests of source and loyalty; he does not wait for the two years to run.
- The prophets call Israel back to the commandments; they are not new lawgivers.
- Isaiah 8:20 sends every voice back "to the law and to the testimony"; Jeremiah 29 applies the same rule to the exiles' prophets, and the LORD's own witness settles the case.

# 4. The Test of Fulfilment

Claim: Moses gives Israel a second test, and it is a test of outcome. If a prophet speaks in the name of the LORD and the thing does not come to pass, the LORD did not speak it. The test settles the matter after the event, which is why the tests of source and loyalty carry the weight in the moment. Micaiah and Jeremiah each stake their office on it.

### 4.1 The two offences and the question

Deuteronomy 18 states the offence before it gives the test. "But the prophet, which shall presume to speak a word in my name, which I have not commanded him to speak, or that shall speak in the name of other gods, even that prophet shall die" (Deuteronomy 18:20). There are two offences: to speak in the LORD's name what he did not command, and to speak in the name of other gods. The second is the offence

of chapter 3. The first is the offence of chapter 2, a word that did not come from the LORD, with the prophet using his name for it.

Then the people's question, put in their own hearts: "And if thou say in thine heart, How shall we know the word which the LORD hath not spoken?" (Deuteronomy 18:21). The question is practical. Israel will hear prophets whose words differ, and she is told how to know the word the LORD has not spoken. The answer follows at once.

**4.2 The test and what it can do**

"When a prophet speaketh in the name of the LORD, if the thing follow not, nor come to pass, that is the thing which the LORD hath not spoken, but the prophet hath spoken it presumptuously: thou shalt not be afraid of him" (Deuteronomy 18:22). The test is stated carefully, and the care is worth noting. It speaks of a prophet who speaks "in the name of the LORD." It speaks of "the thing", an event or a state of affairs that the prophet announced. And it names the verdict: the LORD has not spoken it, the prophet spoke it presumptuously, and Israel need not be afraid of him.

The test has one great strength. It can show that a word was not the LORD's, with no other evidence. A prophet who announces that a thing will happen, and it does not, is shown by the event itself. Nobody has to read the prophet's heart or weigh his conduct. The LORD himself has said what the event means.

The test has one equally plain limit. It acts after the event. A man deciding whether to follow a prophet today cannot use it to decide today. That is the reason the volume puts the test of source (chapter 2) and the test of loyalty (chapter 3) in front of it. In the moment, Israel could ask where a word came from and where it led. The test of fulfilment could confirm the answer later. Chapter 3 showed the other side of the same fact. A fulfilled sign did not validate a word that led from the LORD (Deuteronomy 13:2, 3). The test of fulfilment can condemn a prophet, and it cannot by itself approve one.

**4.3 Micaiah against four hundred**

First Kings 22 is the longest case in Scripture of the tests at work. Ahab king of Israel and Jehoshaphat king of Judah plan to go up against Ramothgilead. Jehoshaphat asks for the word of the LORD: "Enquire, I pray thee, at the word of the LORD to day" (1 Kings 22:5). Ahab gathers about four hundred prophets, and they answer, "Go up; for the Lord shall deliver it into the hand of the king" (1 Kings 22:6). One of them, Zedekiah, makes horns of iron and says, "Thus saith the LORD, With these shalt thou push the Syrians, until thou have consumed them" (1 Kings 22:11). The four hundred speak in the LORD's name, with a symbol, and with one voice.

Jehoshaphat is not satisfied. "Is there not here a prophet of the LORD besides, that we might enquire of him?" (1 Kings 22:7). Ahab names Micaiah and gives his reason for not asking him: "I hate him; for he doth not prophesy good concerning me, but evil" (1 Kings 22:8). A messenger urges Micaiah to join the others: "the words of the prophets declare good unto the king with one mouth: let thy word, I pray thee, be like the word of one of them, and speak that which is good" (1 Kings 22:13). Micaiah answers on the ground of the first test: "As the LORD liveth, what the LORD saith unto me, that will I speak" (1 Kings 22:14).

His first words to the king repeat the four hundred's: "Go, and prosper: for the LORD shall deliver it into the hand of the king" (1 Kings 22:15). The king does not take them

as meant: “How many times shall I adjure thee that thou tell me nothing but that which is true in the name of the LORD?” (1 Kings 22:16). The text does not say how Micaiah spoke. It records that the king heard the answer as other than the truth, and that Micaiah then spoke the word he had been given: “I saw all Israel scattered upon the hills, as sheep that have not a shepherd” (1 Kings 22:17).

**4.4 The lying spirit**

Micaiah then tells what he saw. “I saw the LORD sitting on his throne, and all the host of heaven standing by him on his right hand and on his left” (1 Kings 22:19). The LORD asks, “Who shall persuade Ahab, that he may go up and fall at Ramothgilead?” and a spirit answers, “I will go forth, and I will be a lying spirit in the mouth of all his prophets” (1 Kings 22:20, 22). The LORD sends it. Micaiah draws the conclusion for the king: “the LORD hath put a lying spirit in the mouth of all these thy prophets, and the LORD hath spoken evil concerning thee” (1 Kings 22:23).

The volume reads the passage as judgment on Ahab and not as a licence for the LORD to deceive the innocent. The king had said he hated the one prophet who spoke evil of him (1 Kings 22:8). He had refused the word Micaiah gave in verse 17: “Did I not tell thee that he would prophesy no good concerning me, but evil?” (1 Kings 22:18). The scene Micaiah describes explains why four hundred prophets spoke what they spoke. It does not make their word the LORD’s in the sense of chapter 2. The text itself says the opposite: the LORD “hath put” the spirit in their mouth to persuade a king who would hear only good. Diamond, in chapter 8, calls the spirit the king’s own folly. The volume holds that the text gives the LORD the act, and adds that the act falls on a man who had already shut his ears (see Prophetic Commentary Volume 2 for the same passage).

**4.5 The stake: “the LORD hath not spoken by me”**

Ahab has Micaiah put in prison. Micaiah answers with a sentence that is the test of Deuteronomy 18:22 in his own mouth. “If thou return at all in peace, the LORD hath not spoken by me. And he said, Hearken, O people, every one of you” (1 Kings 22:28). He stakes his whole office on the event. If Ahab returns in peace, he is no prophet. And he calls the people as witnesses.

The event follows. Ahab disguises himself, and “a certain man drew a bow at a venture, and smote the king of Israel between the joints of the harness” (1 Kings 22:34). The king died at evening, and the writer ends the scene by tying it to the word: “according unto the word of the LORD which he spake” (1 Kings 22:38). The test of fulfilment has done what Deuteronomy 18:22 said it would do. The four hundred are shown by the event to have spoken what the LORD had not spoken to them. Micaiah is shown to have spoken from the LORD. The event came after the decision, and the king and the people had to decide before it.

**4.6 Jeremiah 28:8, 9: the rule for the prophet of peace**

Jeremiah 28 states a related rule. Jeremiah answers Hananiah first with “Amen: the LORD do so” (Jeremiah 28:6). He wishes it were true. Then: “The prophets that have been before me and before thee of old prophesied both against many countries, and against great kingdoms, of war, and of evil, and of pestilence. The prophet which prophesieth of peace, when the word of the prophet shall come to pass, then shall the prophet be known, that the LORD hath truly sent him” (Jeremiah 28:8, 9).

The volume reads the rule as a burden of proof laid on one kind of prophet. The earlier prophets had spoken of war, evil and pestilence, which was the burden of the Law's warnings. A prophet who comes against that stream with a word of peace must wait for the event to be known as sent. The verse does not say that every prophet of peace is false. It does not say that a fulfilled word of peace validates a prophet who also teaches rebellion; chapter 3 closed that door. It says that the one who stands against the line of earlier prophets cannot be known by the hearers until the word comes to pass. That is a rule of the test of fulfilment, and it agrees with Deuteronomy 18:22.

The test of fulfilment in three passages.

| Passage | What is announced | What follows |
|---|---|---|
| Deuteronomy 18:20–22 | A word spoken in the LORD's name | If the thing follow not, the LORD has not spoken it; do not fear the prophet |
| 1 Kings 22 | Ahab will prosper (the four hundred); Ahab will fall (Micaiah) | Ahab is struck by a bow drawn at a venture and dies at even (22:34–38) |
| Jeremiah 28:8, 9 | Peace, against the line of prophets who spoke of war and evil | The prophet of peace is known when the word comes to pass |
| What the test cannot do | Decide a case before the event; approve a word that leads from the LORD | The tests of source and loyalty carry the case in the moment |

**4.7 The vision that tarries**

The test of fulfilment can be misused, and the prophets say so. If a word that has not yet come to pass is called false, a patient hearer is punished for patience. Habakkuk is told the opposite. "Write the vision, and make it plain upon tables, that he may run that readeth it. For the vision is yet for an appointed time, but at the end it shall speak, and not lie: though it tarry, wait for it; because it will surely come, it will not tarry" (Habakkuk 2:2, 3). The LORD does not deny that the word has a long road. He says it has an appointed time, and that it speaks at the end.

Ezekiel meets the opposite error in his own day. The people have a proverb: "The days are prolonged, and every vision faileth" (Ezekiel 12:22). It is the mockery of the hearer who has waited and decided the prophets were wrong. The LORD's answer is to end the proverb: "I will make this proverb to cease … The days are at hand, and the effect of every vision" (Ezekiel 12:23). Then he states the principle: "For I am the LORD: I will speak, and the word that I shall speak shall come to pass; it shall be no more prolonged" (Ezekiel 12:25).

Put Habakkuk 2 beside Ezekiel 12 and the volume's position on the test of fulfilment sharpens. The test in Deuteronomy 18:22 concerns a word spoken "in the name of the LORD" that "follow not, nor come to pass." It is the failure of a specific, announced event that shows the LORD has not spoken. It does not license a hearer to declare a word dead because it has not yet come. Habakkuk says the vision tarries and Ezekiel

says the mockers were wrong. A word with an appointed time that has not arrived has not failed.

This is the reason the test carries the least weight in the moment. The hearer who must decide cannot yet see the outcome, and a word that is true may still be waiting. The tests of source and loyalty are what he can apply now. The test of fulfilment is how the LORD answers, in time, the question the hearer could not settle at the start. It confirms or condemns afterward; it does not tell the hearer what to do beforehand.

**4.8 What the volume takes from the passages**

- An announced event that does not come to pass shows that the LORD did not speak the word; the people need not fear the prophet.
- The test acts after the event; the tests of source and loyalty carry the weight when the decision must be made.
- Micaiah stakes his office on the outcome and is vindicated by an arrow drawn at a venture.
- The lying spirit is the LORD's judgment on a king who would hear only good.
- Jeremiah 28:9 lays a burden of proof on the prophet who stands against the line of earlier prophets; it does not turn fulfilment into approval of a word that leads from the LORD.
- Habakkuk 2:2, 3 and Ezekiel 12:21–25 show that a word may tarry without failing; the test of fulfilment condemns a word that did not come to pass at its appointed time, and does not condemn patience.

# 5. The Conditional Word

Claim: an announced judgment or blessing on a people carries its own condition, and the LORD says so himself. Jeremiah 18:7–10 is the rule, Jeremiah 26 shows a prophet preaching under it, and Jonah 3 and 4 show it at work on a city. When Nineveh turned, the forty days did not run out, and Jonah was not a false prophet. Ezekiel 33 applies the same turning to individuals in Israel.

**5.1 The rule the LORD states**

The rule is given at the potter's house, and the LORD states it in two parts. "At what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to pluck up, and to pull down, and to destroy it; if that nation, against whom I have pronounced, turn from their evil, I will repent of the evil that I thought to do unto them" (Jeremiah 18:7, 8). The second part is the mirror: "At what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to build and to plant it; if it do evil in my sight, that it obey not my voice, then I will repent of the good, wherewith I said I would benefit them" (Jeremiah 18:9, 10).

Three things stand out. The rule covers announced judgment and announced blessing alike. It is spoken of "a nation" and "a kingdom", which is to say a people taken as a whole. And the turning is the people's: if the nation turns from its evil, the LORD turns from the evil he thought to do; if it does evil after being promised good, he turns from the good. The word of the prophet and the conduct of the people are bound together by the LORD's own rule.

The rule is the key to a puzzle in the test of fulfilment. Chapter 4 held that an announced event that does not come to pass shows the LORD did not speak it

(Deuteronomy 18:22). Here the LORD says that he may turn aside an announced evil when the nation turns. The two statements fit if Deuteronomy 18:22 is read with Jeremiah 18:7–10. A prophet who announces judgment on a people, and who is sent, is not shown false when the people turn and the judgment is withdrawn. The LORD attached the condition. The tests of the chapters before stay in force: the word still has to come from him and not lead from him.

**5.2 Jeremiah preaching under the rule**

Jeremiah 26 shows a prophet speaking as though he knew the rule. He tells the princes and the people that the LORD sent him "to prophesy against this house and against this city all the words that ye have heard" (Jeremiah 26:12). Then he adds the condition: "Therefore now amend your ways and your doings, and obey the voice of the LORD your God; and the LORD will repent him of the evil that he hath pronounced against you" (Jeremiah 26:13). The judgment is announced and the way out is named in the same breath.

The elders cite a precedent. "Micah the Morasthite prophesied in the days of Hezekiah king of Judah… Thus saith the LORD of hosts; Zion shall be plowed like a field" (Jeremiah 26:18). Then the question: "Did Hezekiah king of Judah and all Judah put him at all to death? did he not fear the LORD, and besought the LORD, and the LORD repented him of the evil which he had pronounced against them?" (Jeremiah 26:19). The elders read Micah's prophecy of Zion's ruin as a conditional word. The king feared the LORD, the LORD repented of the evil, and nobody called Micah false. The elders' argument saved Jeremiah's life, and the text gives no sign that it was thought a mistake.

**5.3 Jonah and the forty days**

Jonah is the plainest case, and the most disputed. The LORD sends him a second time: "Arise, go unto Nineveh, that great city, and preach unto it the preaching that I bid thee" (Jonah 3:2). He goes, and he cries, "Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown" (Jonah 3:4). No condition is stated in the sentence. The people of Nineveh "believed God", proclaimed a fast and put on sackcloth, "from the greatest of them even to the least of them" (Jonah 3:5). The king sets the matter in the form of a question: "Who can tell if God will turn and repent, and turn away from his fierce anger, that we perish not?" (Jonah 3:9).

The Ninevites read the word as conditional, without being told so. The king's "Who can tell if God will turn" treats the sentence as a warning that the LORD might withdraw if they turned. The outcome follows: "And God saw their works, that they turned from their evil way; and God repented of the evil, that he had said that he would do unto them; and he did it not" (Jonah 3:10). Forty days passed. Nineveh was not overthrown.

By the plain reading of Deuteronomy 18:22 alone, Jonah's word failed. By the reading the volume holds, Deuteronomy 18:22 is read with Jeremiah 18:7–10, and the word did not fail. It was a word of the kind Jeremiah 18 describes, spoken to a nation, and the nation turned. The difference between the two readings is not a matter of Jonah's reputation. It is whether a prophet's unfulfilled word may be a true word of the LORD. The volume says that it may, where the LORD attached a condition and the people met it.

Jonah himself settles whether he was surprised. He is angry, and he prays: "I pray thee, O LORD, was not this my saying, when I was yet in my country? Therefore I fled before unto Tarshish: for I knew that thou art a gracious God, and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness, and repentest thee of the evil" (Jonah 4:2). Jonah knew that the LORD might turn from the evil. He fled to Tarshish because of it. He did not think that he had spoken falsely. He feared that he had spoken truly, and that the LORD would do what he had always done.

The LORD's answer ends the book. "And should not I spare Nineveh, that great city, wherein are more than sixscore thousand persons that cannot discern between their right hand and their left hand; and also much cattle?" (Jonah 4:11). The book closes on a question, and the question asks Jonah to accept what Jeremiah 18:8 says the LORD does. The volume adds, with Study 75, that what Nineveh believed is reported in Jonah 3:5 as belief in God. This chapter asks only what the book says about the forty days, and the book says the LORD spared the city when it turned.

**5.4 Ezekiel 33: the same turning, for individuals in Israel**

Ezekiel 33 applies the same movement to persons. The LORD has set Ezekiel as "a watchman unto the house of Israel" (Ezekiel 33:7). The people ask, "If our transgressions and our sins be upon us, and we pine away in them, how should we then live?" (Ezekiel 33:10). The LORD answers, "As I live, saith the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked; but that the wicked turn from his way and live: turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; for why will ye die, O house of Israel?" (Ezekiel 33:11).

Then the statement of the two cases. "When I shall say to the righteous, that he shall surely live; if he trust to his own righteousness, and commit iniquity, all his righteousnesses shall not be remembered; but for his iniquity that he hath committed, he shall die for it" (Ezekiel 33:13). And of the wicked: "if he turn from his sin, and do that which is lawful and right… he shall surely live, he shall not die" (Ezekiel 33:14, 15). The word "surely" in the first clauses is an announced outcome, and the passage says that it can change with the man's turning. The oracle is conditional in the same way the oracles on nations are.

The volume reads this in Israel's setting and nowhere else. The address is to "the house of Israel" (Ezekiel 33:10), the standard is "lawful and right", "the statutes of life" (Ezekiel 33:15), and the life and death in view are life and death under the LORD's government of Israel. The passage is not a statement of how a sinner is saved today, and the volume does not make it the ground of the Body's salvation. The Body is saved by believing the gospel of the grace of God, and the program-specific requirements of Israel's covenant life do not pass to it.

**5.5 The limits of the rule**

The conditional word is not a general escape from the tests. Three limits are plain. First, the rule belongs to the LORD: "At what instant I shall speak" (Jeremiah 18:7, 9). A prophet may not claim a condition the LORD did not attach, and a failed oracle does not become conditional because its author wishes it had been. Second, the rule belongs to a word spoken by a prophet who was sent. The tests of source and loyalty come first. Hananiah's two years have no condition in them, and Jeremiah answers them by the first two tests. Third, the rule is for announced judgments and blessings

on people. It is not a rule about what the LORD has sworn, which is the subject of the next chapter, and the volume never sets it against the sworn covenant promises.

The conditional word in four passages.

| Passage | What is announced | Condition and outcome |
|---|---|---|
| Jeremiah 18:7–10 | Pluck up, pull down, destroy; or build and plant | If the nation turns from evil, the LORD repents of the evil; if it does evil after good, he repents of the good |
| Jeremiah 26:12–19 | Zion plowed like a field (Micah); this house and city | Amend your ways; Hezekiah feared the LORD, and the LORD repented of the evil |
| Jonah 3–4 | "Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown" | Nineveh turned; God repented of the evil and did it not; Jonah knew he would |
| Ezekiel 33:13–16 | The righteous shall surely live; the wicked shall surely die | The outcome changes with the man's trusting or turning; Israel's setting |

**5.6 Joel: "Who knoweth if he will return"**

Joel gives the conditional word its plainest prayer. The LORD says through him, "Turn ye even to me with all your heart, and with fasting, and with weeping, and with mourning" (Joel 2:12). Then the appeal: "Rend your heart, and not your garments, and turn unto the LORD your God: for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness, and repenteth him of the evil" (Joel 2:13). The reason to turn is the LORD's character, and the character includes that he "repenteth him of the evil." That is the same verb the volume meets in Jeremiah 18 and Jonah 3.

Joel then asks the question every honest hearer of a conditional word asks. "Who knoweth if he will return and repent, and leave a blessing behind him?" (Joel 2:14). The question has no promise attached. Joel does not say the LORD will relent, and the king of Nineveh had asked almost the same thing: "Who can tell if God will turn and repent?" (Jonah 3:9). In both places the turning is a real possibility and not a guarantee. The people are told to turn, and the outcome is left in the LORD's hand.

The volume argues from this that the conditional word does not dissolve into a promise or a threat. A hearer cannot treat an announced judgment as certain and decline to turn, and cannot treat it as empty and decline to be afraid. The word comes as a call. Nineveh's king and Joel's prophet both answer it with the same uncertainty and the same action. They do not wait to learn which way the LORD will go. They turn, because the LORD is "gracious and merciful, slow to anger," and because the word they heard could still be turned.

It also answers the charge that the prophets are inconsistent. A prophet who announces judgment and a prophet who calls for turning are not speaking against each other. The announcement is the reason to turn, and the turning is the reason the

announcement may not come. Joel's question and Jonah's story together describe a word built to be answered.

**5.7 What the volume takes from the passages**

- The LORD states the rule: an announced judgment or blessing on a people is turned by the people's turning.
- Micah's prophecy of Zion's ruin was read as conditional by the elders in Jeremiah 26, and nobody called Micah false.
- Jonah is no false prophet: Nineveh read the word as conditional, the LORD spared the city, and Jonah says he knew he would.
- Deuteronomy 18:22 is read together with Jeremiah 18:7–10, and the tests of source and loyalty still come first.
- Ezekiel 33 applies the turning to persons in Israel and is not the ground of the Body's salvation.
- Joel 2:12–14 and Jonah 3:9 show the conditional word as a call: the turning is real, the outcome is left to the LORD, and no hearer is excused from the turning.

# 6. The Sworn Word

Claim: the prophets mark one kind of word as never turned back, and they mark it by its wording. "will not repent", "hath sworn", "I change not" and the oath of Noah's waters are the LORD's own signs of a word that stands. A word marked this way is a different kind of word from the announced judgment of chapter 5, and the prophets never set the two against each other.

**6.1 Balaam's oracle: God is not a man**

Numbers 23 puts the principle into a prophet's mouth who was not an Israelite prophet at all. The LORD put a word in Balaam's mouth, and the word was a blessing on Israel. "God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good?" (Numbers 23:19). Then the ground of the statement: "Behold, I have received commandment to bless: and he hath blessed; and I cannot reverse it" (Numbers 23:20).

The verse is sometimes set against Jeremiah 18:8 and Jonah 3:10, where the LORD repents, as if Scripture contradicted itself. It does not. The oracle of Numbers 23 is about a blessing the LORD has pronounced on Israel, and Balaam says it cannot be reversed. Jeremiah 18 and Jonah 3 are about announced evil on nations, and the LORD says he may turn from it. Two kinds of word are spoken of, and Numbers 23:19 is about the first.

**6.2 One chapter, both uses: 1 Samuel 15**

First Samuel 15 uses the verb both ways in one chapter, and the chapter shows how the distinction works. The LORD says of Saul, "It repenteth me that I have set up Saul to be king: for he is turned back from following me, and hath not performed my commandments" (1 Samuel 15:11). The chapter ends the same way: "the LORD repented that he had made Saul king over Israel" (1 Samuel 15:35). Between those two sentences Samuel says to Saul, "And also the Strength of Israel will not lie nor repent: for he is not a man, that he should repent" (1 Samuel 15:29).

The three verses do not conflict, and the reason is the point of this chapter. In verses 11 and 35 the LORD turns from the thing he had done in setting up a king who then turned back. In verse 29 Samuel is speaking about the LORD's decision on Saul's kingdom, which has been announced and which he will not take back. The word "repent" does not change. What the verse is about does. The reader is to ask, in each place, whether the LORD is speaking of a thing he did, which an unfaithful man has made grievous to him, or of a word he has decided, which he will not turn back.

**6.3 The oath of Noah's waters**

Isaiah gives the plainest example of a word the LORD marks by an oath. "For this is as the waters of Noah unto me: for as I have sworn that the waters of Noah should no more go over the earth; so have I sworn that I would not be wroth with thee, nor rebuke thee" (Isaiah 54:9). Then the way he says it stands: "For the mountains shall depart, and the hills be removed; but my kindness shall not depart from thee, neither shall the covenant of my peace be removed, saith the LORD that hath mercy on thee" (Isaiah 54:10).

Two things mark this as a sworn word. The LORD names an oath: "I have sworn." And he compares it with an oath that history has not turned back, the waters of Noah. The promise to Israel is as fixed as that. The mountains may depart, and the sentence is still not removed. The contrast with Jeremiah 18 is in the wording. Jeremiah 18 says "if that nation… turn", and Isaiah 54 says "shall not depart." The passage contains no "if." The covenant behind it is read in Prophetic Identity Volume 1, and the volume uses its conclusion and does not re-argue it.

**6.4 The word that goes forth**

Isaiah 55 states the LORD's word as a force with a purpose. "For as the rain cometh down, and the snow from heaven, and returneth not thither, but watereth the earth, and maketh it bring forth and bud, that it may give seed to the sower, and bread to the eater: so shall my word be that goeth forth out of my mouth: it shall not return unto me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please, and it shall prosper in the thing whereto I sent it" (Isaiah 55:10, 11).

The last clause carries a point that bears on chapter 5. The word accomplishes what the LORD pleases, and it prospers "in the thing whereto I sent it." A word is measured by the purpose for which it was sent. Jonah's word was sent to bring Nineveh to turn, and Nineveh turned. The word prospered in the thing whereto it was sent, though the city was not overthrown. The verse does not say that every announcement is carried out to the letter regardless of what follows. It says that the word never fails of its purpose, and the purpose is the LORD's. This reading holds the conditional word and the sworn word together without confusing them.

**6.5 "I am the LORD, I change not"**

Malachi gives the sentence in its shortest form. "For I am the LORD, I change not; therefore ye sons of Jacob are not consumed" (Malachi 3:6). The reason Jacob's sons are not consumed is stated, and it is not their conduct. It is the LORD's unchangeableness. The prophet who has just announced the refiner's fire and the purging of the sons of Levi in the verses before it rests Israel's survival on a name, and not on a record. The sentence stands beside the conditional word without cancelling it: nations may be pulled down or built up on their turning, and the sons of

Jacob are not consumed because the LORD does not change toward the oath he swore to the fathers.

**6.6 The LORD marks both kinds: blessing and judgment**

The marking is not only for good words. Psalm 110 sets it on the priesthood: “The LORD hath sworn, and will not repent, Thou art a priest for ever after the order of Melchizedek” (Psalm 110:4). The volume cites the sentence for its wording. The priesthood is read in Typology Commentary Volume 3. And the LORD marks a word of judgment in the same way, when he means it to stand. “I have spoken it, I have purposed it, and will not repent, neither will I turn back from it” (Jeremiah 4:28). Again: “I the LORD have spoken it: it shall come to pass, and I will do it; I will not go back, neither will I spare, neither will I repent” (Ezekiel 24:14).

This is the strongest ground for the volume’s position. A reader who cannot tell a conditional word from a firm one is not left to guess. The LORD marks the firm ones. “Neither will I repent” is not said of Nineveh’s forty days, and it is said of Jerusalem in Ezekiel 24. “Hath sworn” stands on the priesthood of Psalm 110. When no such mark is present, and the word is spoken to a nation, the rule of Jeremiah 18:7–10 applies. The tests of chapters 2 to 4 then settle whether the word came from the LORD, and chapter 5 settles whether it carried a condition. The marks of this chapter settle whether it was one he will not turn back.

**6.7 The covenants the volume does not re-argue**

The great sworn words of the prophets are the covenants. The oath to Abraham (Genesis 22:16, 17), the oath to David (Psalm 89:34–37) and the covenant of Jeremiah 31:35–37 are each read at length elsewhere. Covenantal Commentary Volumes 1, 2 and 5 argue the first two, Prophetic Identity Volume 3 and Study 12 argue the third, and Study 28 reads the oath in Hebrews 6:17, 18. This volume takes their conclusions as its own. Its contribution is smaller and does not repeat theirs: that the prophets themselves mark a sworn word by its wording, and that the marking gives the reader a way to tell a word that stands from a word that turns.

How the prophets mark a word that stands.

| Passage | The wording | What it marks |
|---|---|---|
| Numbers 23:19, 20 | “God is not a man, that he should lie… I cannot reverse it” | A blessing the LORD has pronounced on Israel |
| 1 Samuel 15:29 | “the Strength of Israel will not lie nor repent” | The decision on Saul’s kingdom |
| Isaiah 54:9, 10 | “I have sworn”; “the mountains shall depart” | The covenant of peace, as fixed as Noah’s waters |
| Malachi 3:6 | “I am the LORD, I change not” | The reason Jacob’s sons are not consumed |
| Psalm 110:4; Jeremiah 4:28; Ezekiel 24:14 | “hath sworn, and will not repent”; “I will not go back” | A priesthood, and a judgment, the LORD means to stand |

### 6.8 Psalm 89: chastening and the oath in one passage

The strongest evidence that the conditional word and the sworn word are different things is a passage where both stand together. Psalm 89 reports the LORD's oath to David, and in the same breath says what will happen if David's children fail. "If his children forsake my law, and walk not in my judgments; if they break my statutes, and keep not my commandments; then will I visit their transgression with the rod, and their iniquity with stripes" (Psalm 89:30–32). That is a conditional word, with an "if" and a "then," and a penalty for disobedience.

The next verse does not cancel the oath. "Nevertheless my lovingkindness will I not utterly take from him, nor suffer my faithfulness to fail" (Psalm 89:33). The chastening falls, and the oath stands over it. Then the LORD says what no "if" can touch: "My covenant will I not break, nor alter the thing that is gone out of my lips. Once have I sworn by my holiness that I will not lie unto David. His seed shall endure for ever, and his throne as the sun before me" (Psalm 89:34–36).

The grammar of the passage teaches the volume's distinction. The rod and the stripes are tied to "if," and they fall on the children when the children fail. The covenant is tied to the oath and to the LORD's holiness, and no failure of the children alters "the thing that is gone out of my lips." The two words are not set against each other. They are placed one after the other so that the reader can see which is which. A hearer who read only verses 30 to 32 would think the promise conditional. A hearer who read only verses 34 to 36 would think there was no chastening. The psalm gives both and marks the difference.

This settles a mistake the volume wishes to prevent. It is sometimes argued that because a word may fail through disobedience, no word of the LORD is certain, or that because the covenant is sure, no word is conditional. Psalm 89 refutes both. The prophets mark each word as the LORD gave it. The volume leaves the covenants themselves to the volumes that argue them, and takes from Psalm 89 only the pattern: the chastening is conditional, the oath is not, and the text says which is which.

### 6.9 What the volume takes from the passages

- The prophets mark a word that stands by its wording: "hath sworn", "I change not", "will not repent".
- The verb "repent" is used of the LORD in both senses; the context tells the reader whether he turns from a thing he did or holds to a word he decided.
- Isaiah 55:11 measures a word by the purpose for which it was sent, which holds Jonah's word and the sworn covenants together.
- The mark applies to judgment as well as to blessing; no one is left to guess which words turn and which stand.
- The covenants are read elsewhere; this chapter takes their conclusions and adds the prophets' own way of marking them.
- Psalm 89:30–37 puts the conditional chastening and the sworn covenant side by side and marks the difference in a single passage.

# 7. The New Testament Testimony

Claim: three New Testament letters speak of how the prophets spoke, and each confirms what the prophets said of themselves. Hebrews says God spoke by them in many portions and many ways. First Peter says the Spirit of Christ was in them, and that they searched what he signified. Second Peter says prophecy never came by the will of man. None of the three adds a test, and none adds to the prophets' own faith anything the prophets were not given.

### 7.1 Hebrews 1:1: God spoke by the prophets

"God, who at sundry times and in divers manners spake in time past unto the fathers by the prophets" (Hebrews 1:1). The sentence describes the prophets' speaking in two ways. It was "at sundry times", in many portions across the centuries. And it was "in divers manners", in many ways. The first of these is what chapter 1 found: the LORD made himself known in vision and in dream, and with Moses mouth to mouth (Numbers 12:6–8). The sentence puts them in a single line.

The preposition matters. God "spake… by the prophets." He is the speaker, and the prophets are the ones by whom he speaks. That is the source test of chapter 2 in the New Testament's own wording. A vision "of their own heart" (Jeremiah 23:16) is not what Hebrews 1:1 describes. The prophets are the means, and the speaking is God's.

The verse names its hearers: "unto the fathers." The letter is addressed to Hebrews, and the volume reads the sentence as the letter reads it, on its own audience markers and setting. Study 67 reads the same verse as an audience marker. This volume uses it for another thing, the prophets' mode of speaking, and draws from it no program assignment beyond what the letter itself says.

### 7.2 First Peter 1:10–12: the Spirit in them, and what they searched

Peter writes to "the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia" (1 Peter 1:1), and the volume reads what follows on the letter's own audience markers and setting. His subject is a salvation, and he speaks of the prophets in relation to it. "Of which salvation the prophets have enquired and searched diligently, who prophesied of the grace that should come unto you: searching what, or what manner of time the Spirit of Christ which was in them did signify, when it testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow" (1 Peter 1:10, 11).

The passage says several things, and the volume reports them in order. The prophets prophesied of grace that should come to Peter's readers. They enquired and searched diligently. What they searched was "what, or what manner of time" the Spirit of Christ in them signified. And the Spirit in them "testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow." The sentence has two agents. The Spirit testified, and the prophets searched what he had testified.

The next verse gives the result. "Unto whom it was revealed, that not unto themselves, but unto us they did minister the things, which are now reported unto you by them that have preached the gospel unto you with the Holy Ghost sent down from heaven; which things the angels desire to look into" (1 Peter 1:12). It was revealed to the prophets that their ministry was not finally for themselves. The things they ministered are now reported by those who preach with the Holy Ghost sent down.

Two limits keep the reading honest. First, the passage does not say how much the prophets understood. It says they searched, which implies they did not have the whole in view, and it says the Spirit testified beforehand, which does not say the prophets could state it. The volume draws no more. This agrees with the reading of Amos 3:7 in chapter 1: the LORD revealed to his servants what he would do, and the prophets were not told everything. Second, nothing here adds to the faith of the prophets or of those who heard them. What a man in the prophets' own day believed was what God had said to him. The finished work of Christ and the revelation given to Paul are not added backward to the faith of an earlier believer, and the passage does not ask that they be.

**7.3 Second Peter 1:19–21: not by the will of man**

Peter writes "to them that have obtained like precious faith with us" (2 Peter 1:1), and again the volume reads on the letter's own audience markers and setting. He speaks of prophecy as a light: "We have also a more sure word of prophecy; whereunto ye do well that ye take heed, as unto a light that shineth in a dark place, until the day dawn, and the day star arise in your hearts" (2 Peter 1:19). Then the sentence on which this chapter turns: "Knowing this first, that no prophecy of the scripture is of any private interpretation. For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost" (2 Peter 1:20, 21).

The volume reads the two verses together because the second begins with "For." Verse 21 gives the reason for verse 20. The reason is about the origin of prophecy: it "came not in old time by the will of man", and the men who spoke were "moved by the Holy Ghost." If the reason is about origin, the thing it supports is also about origin. The phrase "private interpretation" then names a prophecy's coming from the prophet's own unfolding of events, which is what Jeremiah 23:16 calls a vision of the prophet's own heart. The verse is the test of source in a New Testament sentence.

Second Peter returns to the prophets at the end: "That ye may be mindful of the words which were spoken before by the holy prophets, and of the commandment of us the apostles of the Lord and Saviour" (2 Peter 3:2). The prophets' words and the apostles' commandment are set side by side. The volume notes the pairing and does not argue from it. Chapter 8 takes up the other reading of "private interpretation", which applies it to the reader.

**7.4 What the three share**

The three passages come from three letters and say three different things, and they agree on one. In each, the speaking of the prophets is God's speaking. Hebrews has God speaking by them in many portions and many ways. First Peter has the Spirit of Christ in them. Second Peter has them moved by the Holy Ghost, not by the will of man. This is the point that chapters 1 and 2 reached from the prophets' own mouths: the word is the LORD's, and he puts it in the prophet's mouth. The New Testament does not correct it, does not add a test, and does not loosen it.

The prophets' speaking in the three letters.

| Letter | What it says of the prophets | Verse |
|---|---|---|
| Hebrews 1:1 | God spoke by the prophets, at sundry times and in divers manners, to the fathers | 1:1 |
| 1 Peter 1:10–12 | The Spirit of Christ in them testified beforehand; they enquired and searched; it was revealed that the things were for "us" | 1:10–12 |
| 2 Peter 1:19–21 | Prophecy came not by the will of man; holy men spake as moved by the Holy Ghost | 1:19–21 |
| What is unsaid | How much a prophet understood of what he spoke; the content of faith beyond what each was told; a new test of a prophet | Chapters 1 and 8 |

**7.5 Testing is carried on, and the Law's sentence is not**

The New Testament does not leave the testing of prophecy behind. Paul tells the assembly at Corinth, "Let the prophets speak two or three, and let the other judge" (1 Corinthians 14:29). He adds that "the spirits of the prophets are subject to the prophets" (1 Corinthians 14:32). To the Thessalonians he writes, "Despise not prophesyings. Prove all things; hold fast that which is good" (1 Thessalonians 5:20, 21). The practice of judging what is said is plain. A word given in the assembly is not accepted because it was given; it is weighed.

John gives the same instruction in his own words. "Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God: because many false prophets are gone out into the world" (1 John 4:1). The letter then offers a confession as the mark: "Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God" (1 John 4:2). This reading rests on the letter's own audience markers and setting. The volume notes that John's test is a test of content, set beside the tests of source and loyalty that the prophets gave, and it does not claim that the letter reproduces them.

The Lord's warning in Matthew 7 belongs in the same discussion but in its own setting. "Beware of false prophets, which come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravening wolves" (Matthew 7:15). "Ye shall know them by their fruits" (Matthew 7:16). The fruit is conduct, and the volume has argued since chapter 2 that conduct is evidence of the source. The Lord also makes plain that prophesying in his name is not itself the proof: "Many will say to me in that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name?" (Matthew 7:22). The reply is, "I never knew you: depart from me, ye that work iniquity" (Matthew 7:23). The saying is spoken to Israel in the Sermon on the Mount, and the volume reports it there.

What the New Testament passages share with the prophets is the practice of testing. What they do not repeat is the sentence of Deuteronomy 13:5. That sentence belongs to Israel under the Law in the land, and the assembly at Corinth is not in that setting. The Body's practice is to judge, to prove and to hold fast, and the volume does not carry the Law's penalty into it. The tests the prophets gave are the roots of the practice, and the practice is the fruit; the sentence stays where Moses set it.

### 7.6 What the volume takes from the passages

- Hebrews 1:1 has God speaking by the prophets in many portions and many ways; the speaker is God.
- First Peter 1:10–12 reports that the Spirit testified beforehand and the prophets searched; it does not say how much they understood.
- No later revelation is added to the faith of an earlier believer; each letter is read on its own audience markers and setting.
- Second Peter 1:20, 21 grounds “private interpretation” in the origin of prophecy: not by the will of man.
- The three letters confirm the prophets’ own testimony about the source and add no new test.
- Paul, John and the Lord each require testing of a prophetic word; the practice is carried on, and the Law’s sentence under Deuteronomy 13:5 stays with Israel in the land.

## 8. Objections and Replies

Claim: the volume’s four tests answer the objections best made against them, and where an objector is right the volume says so. Modern writers who support parts of the argument are named beside those who press against it, each for the position the author has read in a free text. Where no named writer has been read, the objection is stated in the author’s own words and credited to no one.

### 8.1 Objection: no test works in the moment (Mariottini)

Claude Mariottini, an Old Testament scholar who taught at Northern Baptist Seminary, wrote in a post of 9 December 2008 that a hearer has no firm criteria for telling a true prophet from a false one at the moment the prophet speaks, and that fulfilment, the test of Deuteronomy 18:22, confirms the matter only afterwards. This is the most serious objection to a volume that offers tests, and the first half of it is right.

Reply. Chapter 4 says the same thing: the test of fulfilment acts after the event, and Micaiah could not be known by it until Ahab was dead (1 Kings 22:28, 34–38). The volume does not claim a mechanical test that a hearer can run in a moment. It claims that the prophets give three other tests, and that two of them are available before the event. The hearer can ask whether a word leads him from the LORD. Moses gave Israel that question for exactly the case in which the sign has come true: “the LORD your God proveth you, to know whether ye love the LORD your God” (Deuteronomy 13:3). And he can ask whether the word comes from the LORD or from the prophet’s own heart, with the conduct of the prophet as evidence (Jeremiah 23:14, 16). The test of source is harder for the hearer than for the prophet. Jeremiah answered Hananiah when “the word of the LORD came unto Jeremiah” (Jeremiah 28:12). The hearer does not have that. He has the commandments, the fruit of the prophet’s life and the effect of the word on the people (Jeremiah 23:22). It is not certainty. The text does not promise certainty, and the volume does not either.

### 8.2 Objection: Deuteronomy 18 is of no use to a king (Diamond)

James A. Diamond, of the University of Waterloo, wrote in an article of 20 August 2020 on TheTorah.com that the test of Deuteronomy 18 is of no use to a king who must decide before the outcome is known. He adds, of the lying spirit in 1 Kings 22,

that “the lying spirit that enticed him to this folly was himself.” Diamond means that Ahab was already inclined to hear what he wished.

Reply. On the first point the volume agrees, and chapter 4 says it in the same terms. A test that acts after the event cannot decide a war council. That is why the volume places the tests of source and loyalty in front of it, and why Jehoshaphat asks the right question before the event: “Is there not here a prophet of the LORD besides, that we might enquire of him?” (1 Kings 22:7). On the second point the volume partly agrees. Ahab did hear what he wished, and he had said that he hated the prophet who spoke evil of him (1 Kings 22:8). But the text goes further than Diamond’s sentence. Micaiah says, “the LORD hath put a lying spirit in the mouth of all these thy prophets” (1 Kings 22:23). The act is given to the LORD, as judgment on a king who had shut his ears. Diamond’s observation about Ahab’s own inclination fortifies the reading that the judgment fell on a man who had already chosen. It does not remove the LORD from the verse.

**8.3 Objection: the criteria leave doubt (Fortier)**

Janick Fortier, in a 2022 master’s thesis at Trinity Western University on discerning true and false prophets in Jeremiah, treats the criteria of person and message that the book supplies. He concludes that they “do not eliminate all doubts” but are “useful enough to inspire confidence.” The thesis treats Hananiah in Jeremiah 28 within that argument.

Reply. The volume has no quarrel with Fortier’s conclusion and counts it as support. The tests do not remove every doubt. They give a hearer grounds for confidence, and they catch the errors that matter most: a word from a man’s own heart, a word that leads from the LORD, a word that the event refutes. The volume adds that the doubt is not equal on all sides. A false word that leads Israel from the LORD is refused whether or not the hearer is certain how the prophet came by it (Deuteronomy 13:3, 4).

**8.4 Objection: prophets are known by their conduct (Wessels)**

Wilhelm J. Wessels, writing in the Journal for Semitics (2017), reads the rival prophets of Jeremiah 23:9–15 as known to be false by their conduct and because the LORD did not send them (Jeremiah 23:21). He supports chapter 2 as far as it goes. Conduct is real evidence. The volume has said that it is evidence and not the test, and Wessels’s own second ground, that the LORD did not send them, is the test.

**8.5 Objection: Amos 3:7 means the prophets knew everything**

No named writer is cited for this objection, and the author states it in his own words. It says that if the LORD “revealeth his secret unto his servants the prophets” (Amos 3:7), then the prophets must have been told every purpose of God, including the one Paul calls a mystery. Reply. The verse says the LORD “will do” nothing without revealing it. It speaks of what he is about to do in the history of his dealings with Israel and the nations. First Peter 1:11 shows that the prophets themselves searched “what, or what manner of time” the Spirit signified, which shows they were not told everything. And Prophecy & Mystery Volume 2 argues that the Mystery was not foretold by the prophets. Amos 3:7 is a principle about announced events, and it is not a claim about the whole counsel of God.

### 8.6 Objection: Jonah proves that prophets can be wrong

This is stated in the author's own words and credited to no one. It says that Jonah announced the overthrow of Nineveh in forty days, that Nineveh was not overthrown, and that a prophet's word can therefore fail. Reply. It can fail only if the test of Deuteronomy 18:22 is read alone. Chapter 5 shows that the LORD stated the rule of Jeremiah 18:7–10, that the Ninevites read the word as conditional (Jonah 3:9), that the LORD spared the city on its turning (Jonah 3:10), and that Jonah himself knew it would be so (Jonah 4:2). The word prospered "in the thing whereto I sent it" (Isaiah 55:11). It did not fail.

### 8.7 Objection: private interpretation is about the reader

Many commentaries, in the author's experience of them, read 2 Peter 1:20 as a rule for the reader: no one is to interpret Scripture on his own. No single writer is named here, because no text has been read in full that holds the view. Reply. The reading is possible, and the volume does not rule out that Peter's words bear on how Scripture is read. But the word "For" at the start of verse 21 gives the ground of verse 20, and the ground is the origin of prophecy: "the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man." A sentence that explains why prophecy is not of private interpretation by saying where prophecy came from is, on its face, about origin. The volume prefers the reading the grammar gives and holds its judgment of the other reading lightly.

### 8.8 Objection: Numbers 23:19 contradicts Jeremiah 18 and Jonah 3

Again no writer is named. The objection says that if God "is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent" (Numbers 23:19), then Scripture cannot say that he repented of the evil he said he would do (Jonah 3:10). Reply. Chapter 6 shows that the same chapter of 1 Samuel uses the verb both ways, and that the LORD marks a word he will not turn back by its wording. The objection treats the two kinds of word as one. The volume holds that they are two, and that the prophets keep them apart.

The objections and the replies in one table.

| Objection | Held by | Reply in one line |
|---|---|---|
| No test works in the moment | Mariottini | Agreed for fulfilment; source and loyalty are available before the event (Deuteronomy 13:3; Jeremiah 23:16) |
| Deuteronomy 18 is useless to a king | Diamond | Agreed; hence the tests that come first; the LORD still gives the act in 1 Kings 22:23 |
| The criteria leave doubt | Fortier | Agreed; the tests give confidence, not certainty |
| Conduct is the mark | Wessels (partly) | Conduct is evidence; sending is the test (Jeremiah 23:21) |
| Amos 3:7 means the prophets knew all | none named | It speaks of announced events; 1 Peter 1:11 shows they searched |

| Objection | Held by | Reply in one line |
|---|---|---|
| Jonah proves prophets can be wrong | none named | Deuteronomy 18:22 read with Jeremiah 18:7–10; Jonah 4:2 |
| Private interpretation is about the reader | none named | The "For" of 2 Peter 1:21 grounds it in origin |
| Numbers 23:19 contradicts Jonah 3:10 | none named | Two kinds of word, marked by their wording (1 Samuel 15) |

**8.9 What the volume takes from the replies**

- The volume concedes that fulfilment acts only after the event and that no test gives certainty.
- The tests of source and loyalty are available before the event, and the volume rests its weight on them.
- Modern writers fortify the claims about source, conduct and confidence and press on the limits of fulfilment; the volume names each for what the author has read.
- Where no writer has been read, the objection is stated in the author's words and answered from the text.

# Conclusion

The volume began with a plain statement: the prophets give the tests themselves, and the tests are not one rule restated. It has tried to show that from the prophets' own sentences. A prophet is the LORD's appointed spokesman, and the words are put in his mouth (Numbers 12:6–8; Deuteronomy 18:18). A word is known first by where it came from: out of the mouth of the LORD, or out of the prophet's own heart (Jeremiah 23:16; Ezekiel 13:2). It is refused if it leads Israel from the LORD, even when its sign comes true (Deuteronomy 13:1–5). An announced event that does not come to pass was not the LORD's word (Deuteronomy 18:22), unless the LORD attached a condition and the people met it (Jeremiah 18:7–10; Jonah 3:10). And a word the LORD has sworn, or has marked as one he will not turn back, stands (Isaiah 54:9, 10; Malachi 3:6; Ezekiel 24:14).

The position in one table.

| Question | The position | Chief passages |
|---|---|---|
| Who is a prophet? | One the LORD makes himself known to and sends; the words are his | Num 12:6–8; Deut 18:18 |
| Where did the word come from? | Out of the mouth of the LORD, not the prophet's own heart | Jer 23:16, 21; Ezek 13:2, 6 |
| Where does it lead? | A word that leads from the LORD is refused, sign or no sign | Deut 13:1–5; Jer 28:15, 16 |
| Did it come to pass? | If not, the LORD did not speak it; the test acts after the event | Deut 18:22; 1 Kings 22:28, 34–38 |

| Question | The position | Chief passages |
|---|---|---|
| Was there a condition? | An announced judgment or blessing on a people turns when the people turn | Jer 18:7–10; Jonah 3:10; 4:2 |
| Is the word sworn? | A word marked by the LORD's oath or "will not repent" is not turned back | Isa 54:9, 10; Mal 3:6; Ezek 24:14 |
| What do the letters add? | God spoke by the prophets; the Spirit was in them; not by the will of man | Heb 1:1; 1 Pet 1:10–12; 2 Pet 1:21 |

The volume asks to be tested. A reader who disagrees may take any row of the table and look for the verse that overturns it. If the verse is there, the position must change. If it is not, the position stands on what the text says.

The volume has tried to be fair to the readings it opposes. Mariottini and Diamond are right that no test settles a case before the event, and the volume said so. Fortier is right that the criteria give confidence and not certainty. Wessels is right that conduct is evidence. Where the volume has pressed past them, it has done so from the sentences of the prophets, and the sentences are before the reader. If the volume has been unfair, the verses will show it.

# Appendix A. The Tests at a Glance

The four tests and the mark of a sworn word.

| Test | The question it asks | Where it is given | What it can do, and its limit |
|---|---|---|---|
| Source | Did the word come from the LORD, or from the prophet's own heart? | Jeremiah 23:16–22; Ezekiel 13:2–7 | Shows a word is not the LORD's; hard for the hearer to apply alone |
| Loyalty | Does the word lead Israel from the LORD? | Deuteronomy 13:1–5; Jeremiah 28:15, 16 | Refuses a word whatever sign accompanies it; measured by the commandments |
| Fulfilment | Did the announced thing come to pass? | Deuteronomy 18:20–22; 1 Kings 22:28; Jeremiah 28:9 | Shows a word was not the LORD's; acts only after the event |
| Condition | Did the LORD attach a condition, and did the people meet it? | Jeremiah 18:7–10; 26:13; Jonah 3:9, 10 | Explains an unfulfilled word from a sent prophet; belongs to the LORD, not the prophet |
| Oath | Did the LORD swear it or say he will not turn back? | Numbers 23:19; Isaiah 54:9, 10; Malachi 3:6 | Marks a word nothing turns; read apart from the conditional word |

# Appendix B. Key Words

The King James Version is the text of the volume. The words below are given in Roman letters for readers who wish to see what stands behind the English. Nothing in the argument depends on a rendering other than the King James rendering. The notes say what the word is and where it falls.

Words in the passages on the prophets' speaking.

| Word | KJV renders | Where | Note |
|---|---|---|---|
| nābîʾ | prophet | Deuteronomy 13:1, 3, 5; 18:15, 18, 20, 22 | The spokesman; in Deuteronomy 18 the one the LORD raises up |
| ʾôt | sign | Deuteronomy 13:1, 2 | A sign given beside a "wonder"; here a sign that comes to pass |
| sārâ | turn you away; rebellion | Deuteronomy 13:5; Jeremiah 28:16 | The same noun in both; a turning away from the LORD |
| šeqer | lies; lie | Jeremiah 23:25, 26, 32; 28:15 | Falsehood; the word of a prophet who was not sent |
| massāʾ | burden | Jeremiah 23:33–38 | An oracle or a load; the LORD forbids the people's use of "the burden of the LORD" |
| nāham | repent; repented | Numbers 23:19; 1 Samuel 15:11, 29, 35; Jeremiah 18:8, 10; Jonah 3:10; 4:2 | One verb, used of the LORD in more than one sense; the context decides |
| polymerōs, polytropōs | at sundry times; in divers manners | Hebrews 1:1 | In many portions; in many ways |
| epilysis | interpretation | 2 Peter 1:20 | An unloosing or explanation; the volume reads it with the "For" of verse 21 |
| pherō (pheromenoi) | moved | 2 Peter 1:21 | Carried along; the holy men were carried by the Holy Ghost |

# Appendix C. Questions for Study

The questions may be used alone or in a group. Each can be answered from the text, and the chapter that bears on it is given in brackets.

1. What does Numbers 12:6–8 say about how the LORD speaks to a prophet? How is Moses set apart? [1]
2. What three phrases carry the office in Deuteronomy 18:15–19? What is the people's part? [1]
3. What does Amos 3:7 say the LORD does before he acts? What does the volume say it does not say? [1]
4. In Jeremiah 23:16–22, what is the difference between a vision "of their own heart" and one "out of the mouth of the LORD"? [2]
5. Why does the volume call conduct evidence and not the test? [2]
6. Why is a prophet refused in Deuteronomy 13 even when his sign comes to pass? [3]
7. On what two grounds does Jeremiah answer Hananiah in Jeremiah 28:15, 16? [3]
8. What can the test of Deuteronomy 18:22 do, and what can it not do? [4]
9. What does Micaiah stake on the outcome in 1 Kings 22:28? How does the chapter end? [4]
10. What does Jeremiah 18:7–10 say the LORD does when a nation turns? What does the mirror clause say? [5]
11. How do the elders in Jeremiah 26:17–19 use Micah's prophecy? [5]
12. What did the Ninevites understand of Jonah's forty days, and how do you know from the chapter? [5]
13. How does 1 Samuel 15 use the verb "repent" in both senses? What marks the difference? [6]
14. What words in Isaiah 54:9, 10 and Malachi 3:6 mark a sworn word? [6]
15. What does 1 Peter 1:10–12 say the prophets did, and what does it leave unsaid? [7]
16. Why does the volume read 2 Peter 1:20 with the "For" of verse 21? What is the other reading? [7, 8]
17. Which of the objections of chapter 8 have you heard made? What do the verses say? [8]

# Appendix D. The Key Passages in Full

The passages on which the volume turns are given here in full, so that a reader can test the argument against the whole text and not only against the verses quoted in the chapters. Verse numbers are in bold. A row of dots marks a gap between verses.

### D.1 Numbers 12:6–8; 23:19, 20

**6** And he said, Hear now my words: If there be a prophet among you, I the LORD will make myself known unto him in a vision, and will speak unto him in a dream. **7** My servant Moses is not so, who is faithful in all mine house. **8** With him will I speak mouth to mouth, even apparently, and not in dark speeches; and the similitude of the LORD shall he behold: wherefore then were ye not afraid to speak against my servant Moses? … **19** God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good? **20** Behold, I have received commandment to bless: and he hath blessed; and I cannot reverse it.

### D.2 Exodus 4:10–16

**10** And Moses said unto the LORD, O my Lord, I am not eloquent, neither heretofore, nor since thou hast spoken unto thy servant: but I am slow of speech, and of a slow tongue. **11** And the LORD said unto him, Who hath made man's mouth? or who maketh the dumb, or deaf, or the seeing, or the blind? have not I the LORD? **12** Now therefore go, and I will be with thy mouth, and teach thee what thou shalt say. **13** And he said, O my Lord, send, I pray thee, by the hand of him whom thou wilt send. **14** And the anger of the LORD was kindled against Moses, and he said, Is not Aaron the Levite thy brother? I know that he can speak well. And also, behold, he cometh forth to meet thee: and when he seeth thee, he will be glad in his heart. **15** And thou shalt speak unto him, and put words in his mouth: and I will be with thy mouth, and with his mouth, and will teach you what ye shall do. **16** And he shall be thy spokesman unto the people: and he shall be, even he shall be to thee instead of a mouth, and thou shalt be to him instead of God.

### D.3 Deuteronomy 13:1–5

**1** If there arise among you a prophet, or a dreamer of dreams, and giveth thee a sign or a wonder, **2** And the sign or the wonder come to pass, whereof he spake unto thee, saying, Let us go after other gods, which thou hast not known, and let us serve them; **3** Thou shalt not hearken unto the words of that prophet, or that dreamer of dreams: for the LORD your God proveth you, to know whether ye love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul. **4** Ye shall walk after the LORD your God, and fear him, and keep his commandments, and obey his voice, and ye shall serve him, and cleave unto him. **5** And that prophet, or that dreamer of dreams, shall be put to death; because he hath spoken to turn you away from the LORD your God, which brought you out of the land of Egypt, and redeemed you out of the house of bondage, to thrust thee out of the way which the LORD thy God commanded thee to walk in. So shalt thou put the evil away from the midst of thee.

### D.4 Deuteronomy 18:15–22

**15** The LORD thy God will raise up unto thee a Prophet from the midst of thee, of thy brethren, like unto me; unto him ye shall hearken; **16** According to all that thou

desiredst of the LORD thy God in Horeb in the day of the assembly, saying, Let me not hear again the voice of the LORD my God, neither let me see this great fire any more, that I die not. **17** And the LORD said unto me, They have well spoken that which they have spoken. **18** I will raise them up a Prophet from among their brethren, like unto thee, and will put my words in his mouth; and he shall speak unto them all that I shall command him. **19** And it shall come to pass, that whosoever will not hearken unto my words which he shall speak in my name, I will require it of him. **20** But the prophet, which shall presume to speak a word in my name, which I have not commanded him to speak, or that shall speak in the name of other gods, even that prophet shall die. **21** And if thou say in thine heart, How shall we know the word which the LORD hath not spoken? **22** When a prophet speaketh in the name of the LORD, if the thing follow not, nor come to pass, that is the thing which the LORD hath not spoken, but the prophet hath spoken it presumptuously: thou shalt not be afraid of him.

**D.5 1 Kings 22:5–8, 15–23, 28, 34–38**

**5** And Jehoshaphat said unto the king of Israel, Enquire, I pray thee, at the word of the LORD to day. **6** Then the king of Israel gathered the prophets together, about four hundred men, and said unto them, Shall I go against Ramothgilead to battle, or shall I forbear? And they said, Go up; for the Lord shall deliver it into the hand of the king. **7** And Jehoshaphat said, Is there not here a prophet of the LORD besides, that we might enquire of him? **8** And the king of Israel said unto Jehoshaphat, There is yet one man, Micaiah the son of Imlah, by whom we may enquire of the LORD: but I hate him; for he doth not prophesy good concerning me, but evil. And Jehoshaphat said, Let not the king say so. … **15** So he came to the king. And the king said unto him, Micaiah, shall we go against Ramothgilead to battle, or shall we forbear? And he answered him, Go, and prosper: for the LORD shall deliver it into the hand of the king. **16** And the king said unto him, How many times shall I adjure thee that thou tell me nothing but that which is true in the name of the LORD? **17** And he said, I saw all Israel scattered upon the hills, as sheep that have not a shepherd: and the LORD said, These have no master: let them return every man to his house in peace. **18** And the king of Israel said unto Jehoshaphat, Did I not tell thee that he would prophesy no good concerning me, but evil? **19** And he said, Hear thou therefore the word of the LORD: I saw the LORD sitting on his throne, and all the host of heaven standing by him on his right hand and on his left. **20** And the LORD said, Who shall persuade Ahab, that he may go up and fall at Ramothgilead? And one said on this manner, and another said on that manner. **21** And there came forth a spirit, and stood before the LORD, and said, I will persuade him. **22** And the LORD said unto him, Wherewith? And he said, I will go forth, and I will be a lying spirit in the mouth of all his prophets. And he said, Thou shalt persuade him, and prevail also: go forth, and do so. **23** Now therefore, behold, the LORD hath put a lying spirit in the mouth of all these thy prophets, and the LORD hath spoken evil concerning thee. … **28** And Micaiah said, If thou return at all in peace, the LORD hath not spoken by me. And he said, Hearken, O people, every one of you. … **34** And a certain man drew a bow at a venture, and smote the king of Israel between the joints of the harness: wherefore he said unto the driver of his chariot, Turn thine hand, and carry me out of the host; for I am wounded. **35** And the battle increased that day: and the king was stayed up in his chariot against the Syrians, and died at even: and the blood ran out of the wound into the midst of the chariot. **36** And there went a proclamation throughout the host about the going down of the sun,

saying, Every man to his city, and every man to his own country. **37** So the king died, and was brought to Samaria; and they buried the king in Samaria. **38** And one washed the chariot in the pool of Samaria; and the dogs licked up his blood; and they washed his armour; according unto the word of the LORD which he spake.

**D.6 Micah 3:5–8; Lamentations 2:14**

**5** Thus saith the LORD concerning the prophets that make my people err, that bite with their teeth, and cry, Peace; and he that putteth not into their mouths, they even prepare war against him. **6** Therefore night shall be unto you, that ye shall not have a vision; and it shall be dark unto you, that ye shall not divine; and the sun shall go down over the prophets, and the day shall be dark over them. **7** Then shall the seers be ashamed, and the diviners confounded: yea, they shall all cover their lips; for there is no answer of God. **8** But truly I am full of power by the spirit of the LORD, and of judgment, and of might, to declare unto Jacob his transgression, and to Israel his sin. … **14** Thy prophets have seen vain and foolish things for thee: and they have not discovered thine iniquity, to turn away thy captivity; but have seen for thee false burdens and causes of banishment.

**D.7 Isaiah 8:19, 20; Jeremiah 29:8, 9, 21–23**

**19** And when they shall say unto you, Seek unto them that have familiar spirits, and unto wizards that peep, and that mutter: should not a people seek unto their God? for the living to the dead? **20** To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them. … **8** For thus saith the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel; Let not your prophets and your diviners, that be in the midst of you, deceive you, neither hearken to your dreams which ye cause to be dreamed. **9** For they prophesy falsely unto you in my name: I have not sent them, saith the LORD. … **21** Thus saith the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel, of Ahab the son of Kolaiah, and of Zedekiah the son of Maaseiah, which prophesy a lie unto you in my name; Behold, I will deliver them into the hand of Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon; and he shall slay them before your eyes; **22** And of them shall be taken up a curse by all the captivity of Judah which are in Babylon, saying, The LORD make thee like Zedekiah and like Ahab, whom the king of Babylon roasted in the fire; **23** Because they have committed villany in Israel, and have committed adultery with their neighbours' wives, and have spoken lying words in my name, which I have not commanded them; even I know, and am a witness, saith the LORD.

**D.8 Habakkuk 2:2–4; Ezekiel 12:21–25**

**2** And the LORD answered me, and said, Write the vision, and make it plain upon tables, that he may run that readeth it. **3** For the vision is yet for an appointed time, but at the end it shall speak, and not lie: though it tarry, wait for it; because it will surely come, it will not tarry. **4** Behold, his soul which is lifted up is not upright in him: but the just shall live by his faith. … **21** And the word of the LORD came unto me, saying, **22** Son of man, what is that proverb that ye have in the land of Israel, saying, The days are prolonged, and every vision faileth? **23** Tell them therefore, Thus saith the Lord GOD; I will make this proverb to cease, and they shall no more use it as a proverb in Israel; but say unto them, The days are at hand, and the effect of every vision. **24** For there shall be no more any vain vision nor flattering divination within the house of Israel. **25** For I am the LORD: I will speak, and the word that I shall speak shall come to pass; it shall be no more prolonged: for in your days, O rebellious house, will I say the word, and will perform it, saith the Lord GOD.

**D.9 Jeremiah 18:7–10**

**7** At what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to pluck up, and to pull down, and to destroy it; **8** If that nation, against whom I have pronounced, turn from their evil, I will repent of the evil that I thought to do unto them. **9** And at what instant I shall speak concerning a nation, and concerning a kingdom, to build and to plant it; **10** If it do evil in my sight, that it obey not my voice, then I will repent of the good, wherewith I said I would benefit them.

**D.10 Jeremiah 23:16–22**

**16** Thus saith the LORD of hosts, Hearken not unto the words of the prophets that prophesy unto you: they make you vain: they speak a vision of their own heart, and not out of the mouth of the LORD. **17** They say still unto them that despise me, The LORD hath said, Ye shall have peace; and they say unto every one that walketh after the imagination of his own heart, No evil shall come upon you. **18** For who hath stood in the counsel of the LORD, and hath perceived and heard his word? who hath marked his word, and heard it? **19** Behold, a whirlwind of the LORD is gone forth in fury, even a grievous whirlwind: it shall fall grievously upon the head of the wicked. **20** The anger of the LORD shall not return, until he have executed, and till he have performed the thoughts of his heart: in the latter days ye shall consider it perfectly. **21** I have not sent these prophets, yet they ran: I have not spoken to them, yet they prophesied. **22** But if they had stood in my counsel, and had caused my people to hear my words, then they should have turned them from their evil way, and from the evil of their doings.

**D.11 Jeremiah 28:5–17**

**5** Then the prophet Jeremiah said unto the prophet Hananiah in the presence of the priests, and in the presence of all the people that stood in the house of the LORD, **6** Even the prophet Jeremiah said, Amen: the LORD do so: the LORD perform thy words which thou hast prophesied, to bring again the vessels of the LORD's house, and all that is carried away captive, from Babylon into this place. **7** Nevertheless hear thou now this word that I speak in thine ears, and in the ears of all the people; **8** The prophets that have been before me and before thee of old prophesied both against many countries, and against great kingdoms, of war, and of evil, and of pestilence. **9** The prophet which prophesieth of peace, when the word of the prophet shall come to pass, then shall the prophet be known, that the LORD hath truly sent him. **10** Then Hananiah the prophet took the yoke from off the prophet Jeremiah's neck, and brake it. **11** And Hananiah spake in the presence of all the people, saying, Thus saith the LORD; Even so will I break the yoke of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon from the neck of all nations within the space of two full years. And the prophet Jeremiah went his way. **12** Then the word of the LORD came unto Jeremiah the prophet, after that Hananiah the prophet had broken the yoke from off the neck of the prophet Jeremiah, saying, **13** Go and tell Hananiah, saying, Thus saith the LORD; Thou hast broken the yokes of wood; but thou shalt make for them yokes of iron. **14** For thus saith the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel; I have put a yoke of iron upon the neck of all these nations, that they may serve Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon; and they shall serve him: and I have given him the beasts of the field also. **15** Then said the prophet Jeremiah unto Hananiah the prophet, Hear now, Hananiah; The LORD hath not sent thee; but thou makest this people to trust in a lie. **16** Therefore thus saith the LORD; Behold, I will cast thee from off the face of the earth: this year thou shalt die, because

thou hast taught rebellion against the LORD. **17** So Hananiah the prophet died the same year in the seventh month.

**D.12 Jonah 3:1–10; 4:1–4, 11**

**1** And the word of the LORD came unto Jonah the second time, saying, **2** Arise, go unto Nineveh, that great city, and preach unto it the preaching that I bid thee. **3** So Jonah arose, and went unto Nineveh, according to the word of the LORD. Now Nineveh was an exceeding great city of three days' journey. **4** And Jonah began to enter into the city a day's journey, and he cried, and said, Yet forty days, and Nineveh shall be overthrown. **5** So the people of Nineveh believed God, and proclaimed a fast, and put on sackcloth, from the greatest of them even to the least of them. **6** For word came unto the king of Nineveh, and he arose from his throne, and he laid his robe from him, and covered him with sackcloth, and sat in ashes. **7** And he caused it to be proclaimed and published through Nineveh by the decree of the king and his nobles, saying, Let neither man nor beast, herd nor flock, taste any thing: let them not feed, nor drink water: **8** But let man and beast be covered with sackcloth, and cry mightily unto God: yea, let them turn every one from his evil way, and from the violence that is in their hands. **9** Who can tell if God will turn and repent, and turn away from his fierce anger, that we perish not? **10** And God saw their works, that they turned from their evil way; and God repented of the evil, that he had said that he would do unto them; and he did it not. … **1** But it displeased Jonah exceedingly, and he was very angry. **2** And he prayed unto the LORD, and said, I pray thee, O LORD, was not this my saying, when I was yet in my country? Therefore I fled before unto Tarshish: for I knew that thou art a gracious God, and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness, and repentest thee of the evil. **3** Therefore now, O LORD, take, I beseech thee, my life from me; for it is better for me to die than to live. **4** Then said the LORD, Doest thou well to be angry? … **11** And should not I spare Nineveh, that great city, wherein are more than sixscore thousand persons that cannot discern between their right hand and their left hand; and also much cattle?

**D.13 Joel 2:12–14**

**12** Therefore also now, saith the LORD, turn ye even to me with all your heart, and with fasting, and with weeping, and with mourning: **13** And rend your heart, and not your garments, and turn unto the LORD your God: for he is gracious and merciful, slow to anger, and of great kindness, and repenteth him of the evil. **14** Who knoweth if he will return and repent, and leave a blessing behind him; even a meat offering and a drink offering unto the LORD your God?

**D.14 Psalm 89:30–37**

**30** If his children forsake my law, and walk not in my judgments; **31** If they break my statutes, and keep not my commandments; **32** Then will I visit their transgression with the rod, and their iniquity with stripes. **33** Nevertheless my lovingkindness will I not utterly take from him, nor suffer my faithfulness to fail. **34** My covenant will I not break, nor alter the thing that is gone out of my lips. **35** Once have I sworn by my holiness that I will not lie unto David. **36** His seed shall endure for ever, and his throne as the sun before me. **37** It shall be established for ever as the moon, and as a faithful witness in heaven. Selah.

**D.15 Ezekiel 13:1–9**

**1** And the word of the LORD came unto me, saying, **2** Son of man, prophesy against the prophets of Israel that prophesy, and say thou unto them that prophesy out of their own hearts, Hear ye the word of the LORD; **3** Thus saith the Lord GOD; Woe unto the foolish prophets, that follow their own spirit, and have seen nothing! **4** O Israel, thy prophets are like the foxes in the deserts. **5** Ye have not gone up into the gaps, neither made up the hedge for the house of Israel to stand in the battle in the day of the LORD. **6** They have seen vanity and lying divination, saying, The LORD saith: and the LORD hath not sent them: and they have made others to hope that they would confirm the word. **7** Have ye not seen a vain vision, and have ye not spoken a lying divination, whereas ye say, The LORD saith it; albeit I have not spoken? **8** Therefore thus saith the Lord GOD; Because ye have spoken vanity, and seen lies, therefore, behold, I am against you, saith the Lord GOD. **9** And mine hand shall be upon the prophets that see vanity, and that divine lies: they shall not be in the assembly of my people, neither shall they be written in the writing of the house of Israel, neither shall they enter into the land of Israel; and ye shall know that I am the Lord GOD.

**D.16 Ezekiel 33:10–16**

**10** Therefore, O thou son of man, speak unto the house of Israel; Thus ye speak, saying, If our transgressions and our sins be upon us, and we pine away in them, how should we then live? **11** Say unto them, As I live, saith the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked; but that the wicked turn from his way and live: turn ye, turn ye from your evil ways; for why will ye die, O house of Israel? **12** Therefore, thou son of man, say unto the children of thy people, The righteousness of the righteous shall not deliver him in the day of his transgression: as for the wickedness of the wicked, he shall not fall thereby in the day that he turneth from his wickedness; neither shall the righteous be able to live for his righteousness in the day that he sinneth. **13** When I shall say to the righteous, that he shall surely live; if he trust to his own righteousness, and commit iniquity, all his righteousnesses shall not be remembered; but for his iniquity that he hath committed, he shall die for it. **14** Again, when I say unto the wicked, Thou shalt surely die; if he turn from his sin, and do that which is lawful and right; **15** If the wicked restore the pledge, give again that he had robbed, walk in the statutes of life, without committing iniquity; he shall surely live, he shall not die. **16** None of his sins that he hath committed shall be mentioned unto him: he hath done that which is lawful and right; he shall surely live.

**D.17 Isaiah 54:9, 10; 55:10, 11; Malachi 3:6**

**9** For this is as the waters of Noah unto me: for as I have sworn that the waters of Noah should no more go over the earth; so have I sworn that I would not be wroth with thee, nor rebuke thee. **10** For the mountains shall depart, and the hills be removed; but my kindness shall not depart from thee, neither shall the covenant of my peace be removed, saith the LORD that hath mercy on thee. … **10** For as the rain cometh down, and the snow from heaven, and returneth not thither, but watereth the earth, and maketh it bring forth and bud, that it may give seed to the sower, and bread to the eater: **11** So shall my word be that goeth forth out of my mouth: it shall not return unto me void, but it shall accomplish that which I please, and it shall prosper in the thing whereto I sent it. … **6** For I am the LORD, I change not; therefore ye sons of Jacob are not consumed.

**D.18 1 Corinthians 14:29–32; 1 Thessalonians 5:19–21; 1 John 4:1–3**

**29** Let the prophets speak two or three, and let the other judge. **30** If any thing be revealed to another that sitteth by, let the first hold his peace. **31** For ye may all prophesy one by one, that all may learn, and all may be comforted. **32** And the spirits of the prophets are subject to the prophets. … **19** Quench not the Spirit. **20** Despise not prophesyings. **21** Prove all things; hold fast that which is good. … **1** Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God: because many false prophets are gone out into the world. **2** Hereby know ye the Spirit of God: Every spirit that confesseth that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is of God: **3** And every spirit that confesseth not that Jesus Christ is come in the flesh is not of God: and this is that spirit of antichrist, whereof ye have heard that it should come; and even now already is it in the world.

**D.19 Matthew 7:15–23**

**15** Beware of false prophets, which come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravening wolves. **16** Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles? **17** Even so every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit. **18** A good tree cannot bring forth evil fruit, neither can a corrupt tree bring forth good fruit. **19** Every tree that bringeth not forth good fruit is hewn down, and cast into the fire. **20** Wherefore by their fruits ye shall know them. **21** Not every one that saith unto me, Lord, Lord, shall enter into the kingdom of heaven; but he that doeth the will of my Father which is in heaven. **22** Many will say to me in that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied in thy name? and in thy name have cast out devils? and in thy name done many wonderful works? **23** And then will I profess unto them, I never knew you: depart from me, ye that work iniquity.

**D.20 Hebrews 1:1; 1 Peter 1:10–12; 2 Peter 1:19–21**

**1** God, who at sundry times and in divers manners spake in time past unto the fathers by the prophets, … **10** Of which salvation the prophets have enquired and searched diligently, who prophesied of the grace that should come unto you: **11** Searching what, or what manner of time the Spirit of Christ which was in them did signify, when it testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow. **12** Unto whom it was revealed, that not unto themselves, but unto us they did minister the things, which are now reported unto you by them that have preached the gospel unto you with the Holy Ghost sent down from heaven; which things the angels desire to look into. … **19** We have also a more sure word of prophecy; whereunto ye do well that ye take heed, as unto a light that shineth in a dark place, until the day dawn, and the day star arise in your hearts: **20** Knowing this first, that no prophecy of the scripture is of any private interpretation. **21** For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost.

# Appendix E. Where the Passages Are Read

Every passage cited in the chapters, the Preface, the Thesis and the Conclusion, in the order of the Bible, with the pages on which it is read. Each citation is listed as written in the text. The appendices are not indexed. A page number is the number in the footer.

The passages in the order of the Bible.

| Passage | Where it is read | Key passage |
|---|---|---|
| Genesis 22:16, 17 | ch. 6, p. 23 | |
| Exodus 4:10 | ch. 1, p. 6 | In full, Appendix D |
| Exodus 4:11 | ch. 1, p. 6 | In full, Appendix D |
| Exodus 4:12 | ch. 1, p. 6 | In full, Appendix D |
| Exodus 4:12, 15 | ch. 1, p. 6 | In full, Appendix D |
| Exodus 4:15 | ch. 1, p. 6 | In full, Appendix D |
| Exodus 4:16 | ch. 1, p. 6 | In full, Appendix D |
| Numbers 12:6 | ch. 1, pp. 3, 5 | In full, Appendix D |
| Numbers 12:6–8 | ch. 1, p. 5; ch. 7, p. 25; Conclusion, p. 31 | In full, Appendix D |
| Numbers 12:7, 8 | ch. 1, p. 4; ch. 3, p. 10 | In full, Appendix D |
| Numbers 23:19 | Preface, p. 2; ch. 6, p. 21; ch. 8, pp. 30, 31 | In full, Appendix D |
| Numbers 23:19, 20 | ch. 6, p. 23 | In full, Appendix D |
| Numbers 23:20 | ch. 6, p. 21 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:1, 2 | ch. 3, p. 10 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:1–5 | ch. 3, p. 12; Conclusion, p. 31 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:2 | ch. 3, p. 10 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:2, 3 | ch. 4, p. 14 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:3 | ch. 3, p. 10; ch. 8, pp. 28, 30 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:3, 4 | ch. 8, p. 29 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:4 | ch. 3, p. 10 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 13:5 | ch. 3, p. 11; ch. 7, pp. 27, 28 | In full, Appendix D |

| Passage | Where it is read | Key passage |
|---|---|---|
| Deuteronomy 18:15 | ch. 1, p. 4 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 18:15–19 | ch. 1, pp. 4, 5 | In full, Appendix D |
| Deuteronomy 18:16 | ch. 1, p. 4 | In full, Appendix D |
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